

Introduction

The oldest artifacts discovered by archaeologists indicate that human life has always been accompanied by religion and religiosity, although this phenomenon has manifested in specific forms across different eras and continents. The Quran also maintains that throughout history, depending on various temporal and spatial conditions—and in proportion to the capacity of different nations—the manifestation of religion, which is "Islam" (submission to God), has appeared in the form of different divine laws (*shari'as*).

Each of the previous divine laws was the most perfect for its own time, yet they were like the successive grades of a formal education. The final and most perfect among them is the law of Islam, which was presented by the Honorable Prophet.

From its very first day, Islam—with its eternal miracle, the Quran—based its call upon nature (*fitra*) and reason. A divine law that is harmonized with human inner desires and emphasizes reason must be continuous and eternal; the secret of Islam's immortality lies in this very factor. The Quran is a healing medicine dedicated to the purification of human beings; it is a brilliant light that never fades and is, in fact, the eternal guide for humanity.

However, the Quran and its decrees, much like a constitution, contain general principles that require interpretation, clarification, and implementation. God initially placed this responsibility upon the Prophet of Islam and subsequently upon the Infallible Imams. In a narration, the Prophet considers following two things after him as the source of guidance for the Islamic nation: the Quran and his progeny (*itrat*), his *Ahl al-Bayt*. As long as Muslims cling to these two, they are safe from straying—a subtle indication of the inseparable link between the Quran and the *Ahl al-Bayt*, who are the clarifiers and implementers of Quranic teachings.

Islam, which answers all human needs, also has specific instructions for the clarification and implementation of Quranic decrees and the Sunnah of the Infallibles during the occultation of the Master of the Age (may God hasten his reappearance). Islam entrusts this duty to qualified scholars and jurists (*faqih*s) who possess the merit to perform this task. Their goals are none other than the goals of the Prophet and the Infallible Imams; in a sense, their guardianship (*wilayah*) is a reflection of the guardianship of the Prophet and the Infallible Imams. Of course, the realization of such a government during the occultation requires the satisfaction, agreement, and following of the people.

In the book *Islamic Thought 2*, we have endeavored to address established and new issues as much as possible, in accordance with the approved syllabus. Therefore, we request all professors, experts, and students to further enrich this book with their corrective suggestions.

In conclusion, we honor the unremitting efforts of all those involved in the Center for Planning and Compiling Textbooks of the Representative Office of the Supreme Leader in Universities who played a role in producing this work.

Part One: The History of Religion and Prophethood

****a) The Definition of Religion and Its Historical Background****

****b) Judaism and Christianity: Their Origins and Fate****

****c) An Introduction to the Holy Bible (Old and New Testaments) and Its Comparison with the Quran****

****d) The Influence of Christianity on Western Society and Its Comparison with Islam in the Rise of Islamic Civilization****

a) The Definition of Religion and Its Historical Background

****Definition of Religion****

Linguistically, "religion" (dīn) means obedience, submission, following, compliance, surrender, and recompense. In Islamic terminology, it is the set of beliefs, laws, and regulations sent down by God through prophets to guide humanity to well-being and salvation. It encompasses various dimensions: cognitive and doctrinal, ethical, individual, devotional, political, economic, legal and judicial, emotional and psychological, and idealistic. If a religion remains undistorted, it is considered the "True Religion"; if any part of it is corrupted, it is deemed false.

****The Quranic Definition of Religion:**** The only religion with God is *Islam*—which means submission to God. Therefore, whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, it will never be accepted from them. (Quran 3:19)

****The History of Religion****

The history of the True Religion—which is Islam—is as old as humanity itself. When only Adam and Eve existed, Adam was a prophet of God, receiving divine revelations. His religion was very simple, consisting of several fundamental principles: monotheism, belief in the afterlife and eternal life, trust in God sending prophets to guide humanity, and a number of ethical rules and practical commandments.

****The Innate Nature of Religion****

Religion is innate (fiṭrī); meaning the set of beliefs and practices demanded by humanity's inherent nature and existential structure, which nurtures human potential. Monotheism (Tawḥīd), prophethood (Nubuwwah), and resurrection (Ma'ād) are the core elements of religion, required by human nature. The knowledge of and inclination towards God are ingrained and inseparable from the human essence. The desire for eternal life and ultimate ease, achievable in the hereafter, are also innate desires. The general teachings of religion—including worship of God and directives for regulating social relations—are in harmony with human nature and existential structure. Therefore, anyone not estranged from their innate nature accepts it wholeheartedly.

Thus, the innate nature of religion means its content aligns with the inherent structure of human beings.

****The Stages of Religion****

Divine laws (sharā'ī) and religions throughout history share a single underlying truth: Islam (submission to God). Their differences stem from varying degrees of perfection, rooted in the capacities of different nations across time. Different divine laws can be likened to different years in an academic program or stages in treating an illness. All the treatment stages prescribed by a doctor serve one unified goal. Undoubtedly, the patient's condition, time, and nature necessitate these different stages. Hence, the Quran states: "For each [community] among you We have appointed a law and a way." (Quran 5:48)

All these laws and methods are paths toward achieving the same fundamental principles and objectives, shaped according to the capacities of nations and the status of prophets. These paths complement each other; they are not contradictory. The first correct path and method was taught by Adam (AS) to his children. God also sent down the first law through Noah (AS) to guide humanity. The final and most complete law is that of the Noble Prophet of Islam (SAW).

b) Judaism and Christianity: Their Origins and Fate

****The Origin and Fate of Judaism****

Judaism is the name for the religion of Moses (AS), one of the great prophets of God. The people who claim this religion are the Children of Israel (Banī Isrā'īl). "Israel" is one of the names of Jacob (AS), a descendant of Abraham (AS). This nation, which considers Abraham (AS) its great patriarch, calls itself the people of Israel or the Children of Israel. Jacob (AS) had twelve sons, all known as the Children of Israel.

Another name for this people is "Hebrews" or the Hebrew people. The primary language of this religion, Hebrew, is also derived from this name. Some scholars believe the Canaanites gave Abraham (AS) the name "Hebrew" after he entered the land of Canaan. This name later became one of his titles and remained in his family lineage. "Hebrew" comes from the root meaning "to cross over a river," referring to Abraham's (AS) crossing of the Euphrates River into Canaan. Others believe it refers to "Eber," an ancestor of Abraham (AS).

During the rule of Joseph (AS), Jacob (AS) and his children came to Egypt. Joseph (AS), with his influential position in Egypt, saved them from the hardship of famine. At this time, according to the Torah, the house of Israel consisted of seventy people. The population of the Children of Israel grew rapidly, and the twelve tribes, known as the "Tribes," advanced in sciences and skills. This caused fear among the Egyptian pharaohs (Ramses II), leading to their persecution. Priests had also foretold that their power would be destroyed by someone destined from among

the Children of Israel. Consequently, the Pharaoh of Egypt ordered the Hebrew midwives to kill newborn boys but let girls live. However, divine decree had willed that Moses (AS) be born under such circumstances.

When Moses (AS) was born, God inspired his mother to place him in a basket and entrust him to the waves of the Nile River. Moments later, the Pharaoh and his wife retrieved the basket from the water and were drawn to the child. The Pharaoh's wife prevented his killing, saying, "Perhaps he will benefit us, or we may adopt him as a son." Events unfolded such that Moses's mother became his wet-nurse, and she raised him in the Pharaoh's palace until he reached adulthood.

One day, Moses left the Pharaoh's palace, and a series of events forced him to flee Egypt and head towards the land of Midian. There, he married one of the daughters of Shu'ayb (AS) on the condition that he serve Shu'ayb (AS) for eight years, or ten if he wished. After ten years in Midian, he decided to leave for Egypt. On the way, he saw a fire. When he approached it, a voice called out to him from the right side of the valley, from a tree: "O Moses! I am your Lord. I have chosen you as a prophet. Listen to what is revealed." God granted him two miracles: his staff turning into a serpent and his hand becoming radiant white, to help him fulfill his mission. Moses (AS) aimed to call the Pharaoh and his followers to worship God, liberate the Children of Israel from the Pharaoh's oppression, and lead them to the Promised Land. On this path, Moses (AS) asked God to make his brother Aaron (AS) his companion. God accepted his request and chose both as prophets.

Moses and his brother Aaron called the Pharaoh to worship God and resorted to miracles to prove the authenticity of their prophethood. However, the Pharaoh rejected their message, claiming it was obvious magic. He gathered magicians to neutralize Moses's miracle, but they failed. Upon recognizing their weakness against his signs, they fell in prostration, saying, "We believe in the Lord of Aaron and Moses."

When the Pharaoh's schemes failed, he resolved to kill Moses (AS) and torture his followers. God repeatedly afflicted the Egyptians with various punishments: famine, crop failure, storms, locusts, and turning water into blood. Yet, whenever punishment befell them, they would say, "O Moses! Call upon your Lord on account of the covenant He has with you. If He removes this punishment from us, we will believe in you and free the Children of Israel." But they never kept their promise. Following the Pharaoh's decision, God commanded Moses (AS) to lead the Children of Israel out of Egypt by night, to cross the sea and escape the Egyptians. Moses and the Children of Israel set out and reached the seashore at dawn. The Pharaoh, learning of their departure, pursued them with all his might. When his army drew near, God revealed to Moses (AS) to strike the sea with his staff.

Moses (AS) did so, the sea parted, a dry path appeared, and the Children of Israel crossed easily. When the Egyptians tried to follow, the waves engulfed them, and they all drowned. As he drowned, the Pharaoh professed faith, but it was of no avail, and his lifeless body became a lesson for others. After years of hardship, the Children of Israel gained independence and

freedom, settled in the Promised Land, and God showered them with mercy and abundant blessings—even providing clouds for shade and "manna and quail" for sustenance. At this time, Moses (AS) received a mission from God to separate from his people for thirty nights and stay at a special place named Ṭūr. He appointed his brother Aaron as his deputy. After thirty nights, he was commanded to stay another ten days. Finally, after forty nights, he received the Tablets (the Torah) and returned to his people.

Due to Moses's prolonged absence, a man named al-Sāmirī exploited the ignorance and past idolatrous tendencies of the Children of Israel. Using their gold ornaments, he fashioned a golden calf that produced a sound and invited people to worship it. Aaron's guidance was futile, and the Children of Israel, weak in faith, turned to calf-worship. While Moses was at Mount Sinai, his Lord informed him of al-Sāmirī's deception and his people's misguidance. Moses returned to his people saddened and angry.

He first reproached Aaron. Aaron replied, "I feared a split would arise among the Children of Israel. Moreover, they threatened me in your absence and nearly killed me. So do not hold me accountable, and do not make me among the wrongdoers."

When Moses's (AS) anger subsided, he took up the Tablets—a source of guidance and mercy—and turned to his people, reproaching them. He said, "Did God not give you a good promise? Why were you not patient?" The Children of Israel replied they did not break the covenant willingly. Ultimately, they repented, sought God's forgiveness, and God accepted their repentance. However, al-Sāmirī, the instigator of this deviation, was promised punishment in the hereafter and was afflicted in this world with a disease that made him fear being seen by people. Moses (AS) burned the calf and scattered its ashes into the sea.

To complete His favor upon the Children of Israel, God revealed to Moses (AS) to lead them to the holy, Promised Land of Palestine. However, having grown accustomed to a life of humiliation for years and facing difficulties entering that land, they said to Moses (AS) that a tyrannical people lived there and they would not enter unless those people left. Even two men from the Children of Israel with stronger faith encouraged them to go to the holy land, but to no avail. Finally, they spoke harshly to Moses (AS): "O Moses! As long as the inhabitants of the holy land remain there, we will not enter. You and your Lord go and fight; we are sitting right here." At this, Moses felt hopeless and said, "My Lord! Judge between us and the defiantly disobedient people and separate us from them." His prayer was answered. It was declared that this generation was deprived of entering that land—abounding in material and spiritual blessings—and must wander in the wilderness for forty years until another generation could conquer this holy land. According to the Torah, Moses (AS) passed away at the age of 120 in a place called Moab, near the Dead Sea, and the Children of Israel mourned him for thirty days. His grave remains hidden to this day. Later, Joshua son of Nun conquered Jerusalem.

****The Origin and Fate of Christianity****

Mary, the mother of Jesus (AS), was from the family of ʿImrān and a descendant of David (AS). Her parents were righteous and virtuous. Mary's mother was barren and constantly asked God

for a child, vowing that if God granted her a son, she would dedicate him to service at the Sacred House in Jerusalem. God answered her prayer, but instead of a son, granted her a daughter whom she named Mary. Mary's father, 'Imrān, had passed away before her birth. Her mother wondered if a daughter could serve the sanctuary like a son, but it was ultimately decided that Mary would serve. The custodians of the sanctuary disagreed over who should take guardianship of her, as her father held a high and honored position among the attendants and was their leader. Each attendant desired the honor of caring for his child. They finally resorted to drawing lots, and the lot fell to Zechariah.

Zechariah cared for Mary well. Whenever he entered her place of worship, he found food prepared for her. Amazed, he asked Mary, "Where does this food come from?" Mary replied, "It is from God. God provides sustenance for whom He wills without measure." Thus, Mary grew up, and God adorned her heart with the light of knowledge and piety.

One day, as Mary was engaged in prayer and worship as usual, she felt an unprecedented anxiety. At that moment, an angel from heaven appeared before her in the form of a man. Seeing the man, Mary sought refuge in God. The unknown man addressed her: "Do not fear. I am a messenger from your Lord, sent to grant you a pure son."

Mary was astonished and said, "How can I have a son when no man has touched me, nor have I been unchaste?" The angel said, "Thus your Lord has willed. It is easy for Him. He intends to make this event a sign and a mercy from Him for people. The birth of this child is by divine decree and inevitable fate." After a while, Mary felt she was with child and withdrew to a distant place away from her people. When she reached there, the pains of childbirth overcame her. She leaned against the trunk of a dry palm tree, overwhelmed with fear to the point she wished she had died and been forgotten before this event. Once again, God's mercy encompassed her, and a voice said: "Do not grieve; your Lord has provided a stream beneath you. Shake the trunk of the palm tree towards you, and it will drop fresh, ripe dates upon you. So eat and drink and be content. And if you see any person, say, 'Indeed, I have vowed a fast to the Most Merciful, so I will not speak to any person today.'" (Quran 19:24-26) The voice also informed her that the child would speak from the cradle. Hearing these words, Mary found peace and returned to her people with the child.

Under such circumstances, some people confronted her, saying, "What is this strange affair?! Your father was not a bad man, nor was your mother unchaste." In response to this accusation, Mary remained silent and indicated they should speak to the infant. They took this as mockery and said, "How can we speak to a child in the cradle?!" Suddenly, by God's command, the child spoke and said:

[The infant] said, 'Indeed, I am the servant of God. He has given me the Scripture and made me a prophet. And He has made me blessed wherever I am and has enjoined upon me prayer and zakah as long as I remain alive. And [has made me] dutiful to my mother, and He has not made me a wretched tyrant. And peace is upon me the day I was born, the day I will die, and the day I am raised alive.' (Quran 19:30-33)

After these words, people realized this child was created by God's will, possessing high distinctions, and therefore they should cease blaming and reproaching Mary.

When Jesus (AS) reached the age of thirty, an angel conveyed his prophethood to him, and he subsequently received the Gospel from God—a scripture confirming the Torah. His law is considered a completion of the Torah, accepting all that was legislated in it except for certain prohibitions which the Gospel made lawful. At the same time, he foretold the prophet after him, the Noble Prophet of Islam (SAW).

Jesus (AS) strove to guide the Jews from deviation and misguidance back to the right path, as they had distorted the religion of Moses (AS). The Jewish religious leaders decided to confront Jesus (AS) harshly and reject him for exposing their deviations and errors. Unfazed, Jesus (AS) continued his mission. People asked him for miracles to confirm his claim to prophethood. He would fashion a bird from clay, breathe into it, and by God's leave, it would become a living bird. He also healed those born blind and those afflicted with leprosy, revived the dead by God's permission, and informed people of what they ate or stored in their homes. Yet, despite witnessing his miracles, only a few among the Children of Israel believed in him.

Jesus (AS) traveled to various regions to preach his message, tirelessly inviting people to his faith. Consequently, his followers increased. This aroused the anger and wrath of Jewish scholars, who decided to harm or kill him. They even incited the ruling authorities against him, portraying his call as a threat that would destroy the royal palace and Caesar's regime.

Finally, a council of Jewish scholars convened in Jerusalem to discuss how to deal with Jesus and ultimately decided to crucify him. Christians believe Jesus (AS) was crucified. However, God states in the Quran: *** "...and [for] their saying, 'Indeed, we have killed the Messiah, Jesus, the son of Mary, the messenger of God.' And they did not kill him, nor did they crucify him; but [another] was made to resemble him to them. And indeed, those who differ over it are in doubt about it. They have no knowledge of it except the following of assumption. And they did not kill him, for certain. Rather, God raised him to Himself. And God is Exalted in Might and Wise."*** (Quran 4:157-158)

Thus, the mission of one of the major prophets, who possessed a divine law and scripture, came to an end.

Part Two: Aims, Dimensions, and Scope of Religion

a) The Necessity of Revelation and Prophethood

****Introduction****

One of the fundamental principles of Islam is prophethood (*Nubuwwah*). It is the belief that God, in His wisdom, has chosen and sent noble and worthy individuals as prophets to guide humanity towards happiness. These prophets deliver life-giving programs and happiness-creating commands, which they receive through divine revelation. This body of teachings is called "religion," and its carriers are "divine prophets."

****The Necessity of Prophethood****

A key question is: Given human intellect, senses, and acquired knowledge, is there a need for divine prophets? Can't human reason find the path to happiness on its own? Islamic theologians, based on religious sources, argue that humans always need the teachings of prophets for their true happiness. To clarify, we first present some premises:

1. The Creator of all existence (including humans) is wise, and a wise being does not perform futile acts.
2. The purpose of creating any being is for it to reach its desired perfection. God's wisdom requires Him to provide the means to achieve that perfection.
3. Human life is not limited to this worldly life. After this life, humans enter another, eternal life. Life there is the result and reflection of life in this world. Therefore, since every human action and thought affects the eternal life, sufficient knowledge about them—especially regarding God and the afterlife—is necessary.
4. This requisite knowledge is beyond the capacity of human sources of cognition: intellect, senses, and human sciences. The multitude of conflicting views about God, resurrection, ethics, society, law, etc., is evidence of the insufficiency and inadequacy of human reason and knowledge. Even with modern scientific advances, theories are constantly replaced, and many unknowns remain.
5. Therefore, human senses, intellect, and knowledge alone cannot recognize the path to comprehensive happiness. We need another source of infallible knowledge to show us the right path.

Since the wise God created humans to reach perfection and happiness through their own free will, and since eternal happiness is the outcome of worldly life, God must provide another path of knowledge—the teachings of the divine prophets—so that humans can achieve their real

perfection and happiness in the light of both reason and revealed teachings. The Quran and narrations also state that humans need the teachings of prophets to find the right path.

****The Aims of the Prophets' Mission****

Beyond showing the right path for human perfection and happiness, the divine prophets had other important individual and social aims:

1. ****Reminding of Innate Dispositions (*Fitriyyat*)**** Many truths recognized by reason or inherent in human nature are neglected or forgotten due to materialism or misleading propaganda. Prophets remind people, reawaken their dormant nature, and make these truths effective for guidance again.
2. ****Liberating Humans from Incorrect Bonds**** One aim of prophets is to free people from false and wrongful traditions and values. They fight these incorrect customs, liberate humans from the shackles of internal and external tyranny, and guide them from darkness to light.
3. ****Calling to Monotheism (*Tawhid*)**** The most important goal of prophets is to invite humans to monotheism and to avoid polytheism (*Shirk*). Acceptance of monotheism in all its theoretical and practical dimensions is essential for salvation.
4. ****Establishing Equity and Justice in Human Society**** Prophets were sent with clear proofs, the Book, and the Balance so that people might uphold justice.
5. ****Acquainting People with Divine Wisdom and Purifying Them**** Prophets teach people God's verses, purify them from moral vices, and make them worthy of receiving the Book and wisdom.
6. ****Giving Glad Tidings and Warnings**** Prophets have the duty to give good news and warnings, completing the proof for people and closing the door to excuses.
7. ****Healing Spiritual Diseases**** Another aim of the prophets is to treat human spiritual ailments. The Quran itself is mentioned as a healing remedy.
8. ****Perfecting Moral Virtues**** Prophets call people to moral virtues and dignities and elevate them in this aspect. Prophet Muhammad said, "I was sent to perfect noble morals."

In summary, the aim of the prophets' mission can be stated as: "To enjoin all that is good and forbid all that is evil."

b) The Miracles of the Prophets

****The Meaning of Miracle (*Mu'jizah*)****

Literally, *Mu'jizah* is derived from **Ajz** (incapacity/weakness). Terminologically, it refers to an extraordinary act performed by divine prophets to prove their claim of prophethood. They challenge people to bring something like it, and people are unable to do so. Miracles are extraordinary acts that defy ordinary natural laws (e.g., Moses' staff turning into a serpent). They are accompanied by a claim of prophethood and a challenge (*Tahaddi*), and they are neither teachable nor nullifiable by others. Extraordinary acts without a claim of prophethood and challenge are called **Karamah** (gracious favor).

****Miracles and Rational Laws****

Are the miracles of divine prophets compatible with rational laws like causality? Miracles are not against rational laws, though they may be against ordinary natural laws. The belief that a miracle violates causality stems from a materialistic view that sees only known material causes for events. However, an event (miracle or not) can have non-material or supernatural causes beyond the scope of the material world and empirical sciences. Causes for a phenomenon can be:

1. Ordinary, known natural causes.
2. Unknown natural causes.
3. The influence of powerful souls and spirits.
4. Non-material causes (e.g., angels acting by God's command).

Therefore, all miracles have a cause, though that cause may be unknown to us.

c) The Infallibility (*'Ismah*) of the Prophets

****The Meaning of Infallibility****

'Ismah linguistically means protection and immunity. Terminologically, it is a special immunity or an internal faculty that protects prophets from committing sins and errors, and it is a condition for prophethood.

****Types of Infallibility****

The infallibility of prophets can be examined in three realms:

1. ****Infallibility in Receiving, Preserving, and Conveying Revelation:**** This is agreed upon by all Islamic theologians. Without it, the goal of prophethood would not be achieved. Rational and textual proofs support this.
2. ****Infallibility from Sin and Disobedience:**** Prophets must be immune from committing sins in practicing the laws of their own religion. Rational proof: Prophets teach both through speech and action. If their actions contradict their words, people would be misled, and the goal of prophethood would fail, contradicting divine wisdom. Their educational role also necessitates their purity. Textual proofs from the Quran also emphasize their purity and protection from Satan's influence.
3. ****Infallibility from Error in Personal and Social Matters:**** Prophets should also be immune from mistakes and forgetfulness in ordinary matters, as these could diminish people's trust in them. While common people may struggle to differentiate between an error in daily life and an error in conveying divine laws, such errors could still negatively impact their credibility.

****The Source and Cause of Infallibility****

Islamic theologians point to two main factors:

1. ****Supreme Knowledge and Love of God:**** Prophets and saints possess such a profound recognition of God's greatness, beauty, and majesty that it prevents them from paying attention to or loving anything other than God. The thought of sin does not even cross their minds.
2. ****Complete Awareness of Consequences:**** They have full awareness of the good results of obeying God and the terrible outcomes of sin and disobedience. A rational person who knows the severe consequences of an act naturally refrains from it. This awareness, coupled with a strong will and divine grace, grants them immunity.

****Infallibility and Free Will****

Infallibility does not contradict free will. Prophets possess the faculty of infallibility and do not err, but they *could* choose to commit sins if they willed—they simply do not, just as a rational person *could* touch a live wire but chooses not to. The Quran also indicates the Prophet's ability to disobey, though he never did.

d) The Role of Religion in Worldly Life

Today, questions are raised about the scope of religion's influence: Is religion revealed only for human happiness in the afterlife, or does it also address happiness and management of worldly life? Does it only emphasize the individual aspect, or does it also address the social dimension?

Two views exist: One says religion is individual and concerns otherworldly happiness. The other says God sent religion for happiness in both this world and the next, with otherworldly happiness being a result of a happy worldly life achieved through following religious teachings. The aims of the prophets indicate that religion plays a significant role in all pillars of human life.

****1. The Comprehensiveness and Perfection of Religion****

Islam is the final religion revealed by God through the Seal of the Prophets for the guidance, perfection, and happiness of humanity. Human actions have various dimensions: individual/social, physical/spiritual, worldly/otherworldly. They are directed towards oneself, God, or society. Social life itself has dimensions like ethics, law, economics, international relations, and governance.

The comprehensiveness of religion means that Islam addresses all these dimensions and has established general and specific principles for each, commensurate with human needs, so that by acting upon them, humans can achieve comprehensive happiness. Islam is complete and lacks nothing in responding to human needs. The Quran states, *"Today I have perfected your religion for you..."* (5:3). Imam Ali also said God perfected His religion.

****Objections:****

* ****Objection 1:**** Some erroneously think religion was revealed for otherworldly happiness and that managing worldly life is entrusted to human intellect—a secularist thought incompatible with Islam. The Quran mentions that part of the prophets' goals includes regulating social relations

based on justice and fighting social corruption, which undoubtedly requires forming a government.

* **Objection 2:** Some argue that since Islamic principles are eternal and fixed, while human life is variable, how can fixed principles be compatible with a changing life? Therefore, religion must be for the afterlife only.

* **Response:** First, the afterlife is not separate from worldly life; this world is the farm for the hereafter. Second, implementing many divine laws requires forming a government and managing worldly life by religious authorities. Furthermore, the Quran and narrations often state fixed general principles from which rulings for new issues can be derived, just like fixed mathematical principles can solve various problems. Some human needs are constant, though their forms and examples change (e.g., the command to build defensive power; its examples change from swords to missiles).

Divine revelation, aiding reason, can secure human happiness in both worlds.

2. Secularism

Today, in Western societies, there exists a thought that seeks to manage human worldly life without the aid of religion. Adherents of this view limit religion's influence to the private and personal sphere of life.

Definition of Secularism: A Western concept describing a specific worldview and approach to managing society that emerged under specific Western conditions. In Persian, it means worldliness, world-centeredness, religion-avoidance, and separation of religion.

Terminologically, it is an ideology whose advocates consciously deny all supernatural matters and related intermediaries and functions, and defend non-religious or anti-religious principles as the basis for personal ethics and social organization. Philosophically, secularism manifests in rational systems of thought and behavior, completely ignoring or criticizing revelatory and supernatural teachings. Politically, it tries to keep politics free from the influence of religious teachings. In education, it tries to remove religious teachings from curricula.

Grounds and Factors for the Emergence of Secularism:

- Distorted Sacred Texts:** Misinterpretations of the Christian Bible paved the way. For example, Jesus's saying, "Render unto Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and unto God the things that are God's," was interpreted as separating religion and divine matters from politics and government. Also, Jesus saying his kingdom "is not of this world" was taken to declare the separation of religion from politics.
- Lack of Social/Governmental Laws in Christianity:** Christianity lacks a detailed social/legal code (Sharia). Early Christian councils abrogated the Law of Moses, leaving only a few prohibitions. Naturally, without religious laws for social life, recourse had to be made to rational laws.
- Incompatibility of Some Christian Doctrines with Reason and Science:** Doctrines like the Trinity, Original Sin, Crucifixion, Divinity of Jesus, etc., were seen as irrational. Furthermore,

Christian theology became so intertwined with Aristotelian philosophy (e.g., by Augustine and Aquinas) that criticizing Aristotle's cosmology was seen as attacking Christianity.

4. ****Wrong Conduct by Church Authorities:**** Financial and moral corruption of the clergy, sale of indulgences, and the harsh Inquisition courts drove people away from religion and the Church.

5. ****Harsh Treatment of Scientists:**** The Church's violent opposition to new scientific theories (e.g., Galileo, Darwin) created the belief among intellectuals that one had to choose between religion or science and progress. Instead of fighting the distorted religion and corrupt clergy, they mistakenly abandoned religion itself.

****Foundations of Secularism:****

1. ****Scientism:**** The belief in the necessity of making empirical sciences and the experimental method central in all aspects of life. Due to the success of empirical sciences, some thought a similar system could be designed for worldly life. Since the scientific method is mechanical (observation/experiment), the world was seen as a mechanical machine where every event has a necessary material cause, making the supernatural unnecessary. Non-empirical fields like ethics, metaphysics, and religion were sidelined from knowledge. Scientism's backing is a kind of materialism that limits existence to the material world.

2. ****Rationalism (in the secular sense):**** The belief that all behavior and beliefs should be based on reason, not emotions or religious beliefs—where 'reason' is understood as not benefiting from religious principles. Renaissance thinkers, given reason's ability in science, thought reason could replace religion in all spheres of life. Factors leading to this included irrational Christian doctrines and the Church's harsh treatment of philosophers.

****Critique and Examination:****

* Secularism is a phenomenon born in Western society under specific conditions. The Church's wrong conduct played a major role in setting religion aside.

* ****Critique of Scientism:**** While Islam values science, the domain of empirical sciences is limited to the material world and experimentation. It cannot affirm or deny the supernatural; its position there is agnostic. Using science in material life is commendable, but using it to justify all human dimensions (ethical, spiritual, supernatural) is incorrect. Scientific findings lack absolute certainty and are constantly revised. Belief in God and the afterlife plays a decisive role in organizing human life, but scientism and materialism ignore this, depriving humans of other realms of knowledge.

* ****Critique of (Secular) Rationalism:**** While reason is respected in Islam, using it alone cannot lead to happiness in both worlds. Human reason is fraught with disagreements and contradictions in managing life. It grasps general good and evil (e.g., justice is good, oppression is bad) but struggles to identify their specific instances. Therefore, reason alone cannot be a complete guide.

* ****Islam's View on Secularism:**** From Islam's perspective, prophets were sent to save humans from darkness, establish justice, and promote moral virtues. This necessitates that prophets assume leadership of human society. Some Muslims who support secularism and limit religion to individual issues have distanced themselves from Islamic teachings. Prophet Muhammad undertook the guidance of both religious and worldly affairs of the people, and the

infallible Imams after him continued this. The Quran indicates that religion is compatible with sovereignty and political management (4:54). Implementing Islamic laws requires forming a government. Belief in the global government of Imam Mahdi (aj) also shows that religion's involvement in social and governmental issues is a religious teaching itself. Therefore, religion is intertwined with managing people's worldly life, and secularism is incompatible with Quranic teachings.

****3. Liberalism****

Today, Western societies try to defend an ideology called Liberalism and make it the headline of their lives.

****Meaning:**** Liberalism means freedom-loving, derived from 'liberal.' It is a phenomenon and ideology of industrial Western civilization. As a philosophical system, it does not become a closed system of thought with fixed, unchangeable principles. It can be described as an outlook on life and its issues that emphasizes values like freedom for individuals, minorities, and nations.

****Founding Values of Liberalism:****

1. ****Individualism:**** Giving priority to the individual over any social group or collective body. The individual is an end, not a means for others' interests.
2. ****Freedom:**** Belief in the high stature of the individual leads to a commitment to their freedom. Liberals believe life without freedom is not worth living. They want to free the individual from unwarranted constraints imposed by governments, institutions, and traditions. However, they do not believe in absolute, unlimited freedom, as that could harm others.
3. ****Rationalism (Liberal sense):**** Defense of freedom is closely linked to belief in rationalism. From this view, humans with their reason can recognize and pursue their best interests, take charge of their lives, and shape their destiny. Therefore, liberals see reason, not revelation, as their guide. Due to this rationalism, they defend freedom of belief and religion, but also freedom from religion. They see the church as a private institution. Achieving complete religious freedom requires making public life secular or non-religious. They advocate separation of church and state, universal non-religious education, civil marriage, and divorce laws.
4. ****Justice and Equality of Human Rights:**** All individuals have equal rights and respect, are equal before the law, and have the right to civil liberty. No law should grant special privileges to some or impose special discrimination on others. Liberals see wealth acquisition as a sign of individual merit.
5. ****Tolerance:**** Tolerance is a moral ideal and social principle allowing people to speak and act in ways we may not like. Civil liberties (free speech, association, religion) guarantee tolerance. Liberalism thus encourages moral and cultural relativism.

****Critique and Examination:****

Liberalism is a product of industrial West. Some of its general titles (respect for individual, justice, following reason, peaceful coexistence) are acceptable to reason and Islam in principle, but Islam gives them specific meanings.

1. ****Problem with Freedom:**** The crucial question is: Free to do what? Humans have two sets of tendencies: animalistic/egoistic desires and lofty human desires. If left free without guidance, many follow base desires (corruption, gambling, promiscuity, addiction, exploitation). Liberal man is freed from external chains but becomes a slave to his inner desires, which is a baser slavery. One aim of prophets is to purify humans so they can grow in human attributes and not become slaves to lust. Therefore, education and life conditions should be planned to foster moral growth, not be neutral or even promote animalistic traits. Liberalism's main flaw is that it tries to seemingly free humans from external obligations but entraps them in servitude to their own whims.
2. ****Problem with Rationalism:**** Liberals take reason, not revelation, as their guide. This belief stems from Christian doctrines where core beliefs (Trinity, etc.) conflict with reason, forcing a choice between reason or religion. This perception is incorrect in Islam. In Islam, wise people are those who accept God and religion. Reason is the "inner proof" equal to the "outer proof" (prophets). Reason itself guides humans to religion to manage their society based on religious teachings, which foster moral and human growth.
3. ****Problem with Secular Governance:**** Based on their rationalism, liberals believe in secular government where religious and governing institutions are separate. They believe religion is a private matter and should not interfere in the social sphere. The problem is that we have predetermined for religion where it can and cannot interfere. If investigation shows that many of Islam's teachings relate to the social sphere, can we tell Muslims to be religious but consider many of its teachings incorrect? Privatizing religion might be somewhat applicable to Christianity, which lacks a detailed social program, but it is not correct regarding Islam.
4. ****Problem with Justice:**** Another liberal principle is justice and equality before the law. While equality before the law is good, justice is not limited to this. What does justice mean in the structure of government? Should rulers have other moral qualities? Should they focus only on material/animal aspects or also on moral virtues? Should government preserve the family institution or facilitate its dissolution? Justice in legislation? We can only enact wise laws when we fully know the dimensions of human existence—something beyond human capacity. Only God, the Creator, with His infinite wisdom, can establish such wise laws, which have been manifested in religious commandments. One goal of sending prophets is to establish justice in society. Evidence shows that if justice is to be implemented in all dimensions of society, divine prophets are better suited for this task than liberals.

In practice, Liberalism has shown such weakness and instability that history witnesses the failure of its resulting principles and values.

e) The Common Essence of Religion and the Secret of the Multiplicity of Religions

****The Common Essence of Religion****

The common essence and truth of all divine religions is "Islam," which means submission to God. All religions share common principles: Monotheism (*Tawhid*), Prophethood

(*Nubuwwah*), Resurrection (*Ma'ad*), as well as ethical principles and general individual and social laws.

****The Secret of the Multiplicity of Religions (*Shara'i')****

Human life conditions throughout history necessitate that some detailed and subsidiary laws differ. Since these conditions change, the laws suited to them also change—this is the secret of the multiplicity and abrogation (*Naskh*) of religions. God says, *"For each [community] among you We had appointed a code [of law] and a method"* (5:48). Thus, various religions are formed according to people's capacity, life conditions, and the status of the prophets. All share common principles but differ in some laws as required by their time, with a later religion abrogating the previous one in that regard. The final religion, whose message is valid until the Day of Resurrection and after which there will be no other, is the religion of the Seal of the Prophets.

****The Secret of the Eternity and Truth of Islamic Law****

Since Islam is the last and most complete religion, its fundamental laws are eternal. The Quran and Islamic narrations explicitly state the eternity of Islam's laws. God declares that falsehood cannot approach the Quran. The Prophet said, *"Its lawful is lawful until the Day of Resurrection, and its unlawful is unlawful until the Day of Resurrection."*

The reason for its eternity is that Islamic laws are based on the existential structure and innate nature (*Fitrah*) of humans. Since this essential nature remains constant through ages, Islamic laws are also constant and enduring. Although industry and technology change the form of life, they cannot change human nature. A set of matters arising from human nature remain constant: love of learning, growth, love for fellow humans and environment, inclination to trade and private ownership, social/family relations, need for spouse/shelter/clothing, self-preservation, love for beauty, and ethical issues like inclination to justice, duty, helping others, sacrifice, and avoiding oppression, lying, and betrayal. Although the form of life has changed today, these innate human matters remain constant. The Quran emphasizes that the inclination to religion is a requirement of human nature, and this nature does not change.

****Q:** With new issues constantly arising, how can fixed Islamic laws determine rulings for all of them?

****A:**** The sources of Islamic rulings are so rich and vast that the ruling for any issue can be determined from them, similar to how mathematicians solve any problem using basic mathematical principles. Islamic scholars, besides rich religious sources, have other tools:

1. ****The Authority of Sound Reason:**** Islam validates sound rational judgments, making reason a source of Islamic jurisprudence.
2. ****The Principle of Prioritizing the More Important (*Ahamm wa Muhimm*)**** Since Islamic laws follow interests (*Masalih*) and harms (*Mafasid*), and these are not equal, scholars weigh them and sacrifice the lesser interest for the more important one.
3. ****The Open Door of Ijtihad (Independent Juridical Reasoning)**** This, a distinction of the Shiite school, is a factor in Islam's eternity. Scholars, using the Quran, narrations, consensus, and reason, through continuous dynamic Ijtihad, deduce rulings for new events and issues.

4. ****Following Governing Jurisprudential Principles:**** In Islamic law, there are principles like "Negation of Hardship" and "Negation of Harm," which scholars use to solve many problems. These "governing rules" oversee all Islamic laws; any ruling that causes unbearable hardship or harm is lifted.

Thus, Islamic law is eternal and can forever respond to human religious needs.

****Religious Pluralism and the Common Essence****

Today, explaining religious diversity is an important issue in philosophy of religion. The key question is: Do different religions and laws possess equal truth and salvific efficacy? Are all true and following them leads to salvation, or is only one true, or does following one lead to salvation while followers of others are saved under certain conditions?

Views can be categorized into three:

1. ****Exclusivism:**** Only one religion possesses complete truth. Others may have some truth but are not absolutely true. Only its genuine followers are absolutely saved.

* ****Critique:**** Islam, as the final and most complete divine religion, considers itself the absolute truth and savior. However, it confirms previous religions and states that other religions have been distorted, and their followers can be saved under certain conditions. Islam presents the Quran as its eternal miracle as proof. When multiple religions claim absolute truth, people must evaluate their proofs and choose the strongest. Exclusivism is criticized as incompatible with God's vast mercy. In response, Islam, while believing in its absolute truth, also believes in God's all-encompassing mercy. People are divided into two groups: those who, due to environmental/educational factors, could not recognize Islam's truth and are not punished for intellectual incapacity; and those who had access to the final divine law and could distinguish truth but obstinately insisted on following their ancestors' ways—these will face punishment.

2. ****Inclusivism:**** One specific religion is the absolute truth and its followers are saved, but followers of other religions can also be saved to the extent they conform to the true religion. Its origin is the Christian world. Defenders say although Christianity has absolute truth, non-Christians can attain eternal happiness (e.g., Karl Rahner's "anonymous Christians").

* ****Critique:**** Inclusivism is not a realistic explanation of religious diversity. If followers of every religion consider theirs the truth and others its anonymous followers, we face conflicting truth claims. It is each person's duty to reflect and try to reach the correct teaching. If someone, through reason, concludes that God is one, Prophet Muhammad's teachings are revelation, and the Quran is an eternal miracle, yet insists on opposing them, can they still be saved? Since God holds such people accountable, they cannot be saved. Inclusivism seems contrary to Islam's view. Islam considers followers of other religions saved under conditions, but not universally. Also, followers of each religion must refer to their own sources to see who is saved. If a religion's sources do not consider followers of other religions saved, how can its adherents believe in inclusivism?

3. **Pluralism:** All religions simultaneously possess equal truth and salvific efficacy. It considers the various (sometimes contradictory) teachings of all religions equally correct and their followers all saved, making no distinction. John Hick is a prominent defender.

* **Critique:***

1. Hick philosophically believes a transcendent reality exists, but no religion should attribute its concepts and interpretations to it. How did he arrive at this belief? If there is a method to know this, we could use it to discover other attributes of that reality and attribute them correctly, making one interpretation correct, not all. If there's no method, how can its existence be discovered? He faces a dilemma.

2. This view contradicts the beliefs of various religions. Each religion considers its interpretation of God correct and others wrong. For example, Islam believes God is one, creator, merciful, etc., and considers any contrary interpretation incorrect. Telling Muslims not to attribute their interpretation to the transcendent is unacceptable to them.

3. The Quran, as divine revelation, introduces Prophet Muhammad as a messenger for all worlds and itself as a heavenly book for all people, making no exception. It even criticizes the People of the Book for not following Islam. The Prophet's letters to kings and leaders invited them to Islam. Therefore, pluralism is not a correct explanation for different religions and contradicts Quranic teachings. The correct explanation is Islam's own view of religions and divine laws.

f) The Relationship Between Science and Religion

Introduction

After the Renaissance and the Church's wrong treatment of scientists, the relationship between empirical sciences and religion received more attention in religious studies. Are scientific findings compatible or incompatible with religion? What kind of relationship exists between science and religion? Can observation and experiment be applied to supernatural matters? What is Islam's verdict on empirical sciences?

Definitions:

* **Science:** Here, it primarily means empirical sciences—those based on observation and experiment, like physics, biology, chemistry, astronomy.

* **Religion:** Here, it means divinely revealed religions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam)—teachings God sent via prophets for human guidance. These teachings have dimensions related to the unseen, ethics, individual/social duties, and views about the world, humans, and historical events.

Characteristics of Empirical Sciences:

1. Obtained through the experimental method (observation/experiment). Its domain is material matters; it cannot operate or comment on non-material, non-empirical matters.
2. Scientific concepts and laws represent the objective world; scientists are generally realists.

3. In empirical sciences, no theory can be proven with absolute certainty. At most, a theory has greater agreement with existing data. Successful formulations are always subject to revision. Some philosophers advocate probabilistic validation.
4. Scientific activity often occurs within a "paradigm" (T.S. Kuhn). A paradigm shift constitutes a scientific revolution, where old terms take new meanings.

Thus, scientific theories/laws are never presented as certain; they are always provisional. Nonetheless, science's progress led some to think the scientific method is the only way to discover truth, and anything not verifiable by sense observation is false/meaningless. This led to sidelining ethics, metaphysics, and religious issues, and the scientific outlook led to materialistic/atheistic philosophy—itself a philosophical conclusion, not a scientific finding. The scientific method discovers relations between material phenomena and cannot affirmatively or negatively comment beyond them. Its position regarding the supernatural is agnostic, not negating.

****Islam's View on Empirical Sciences****

The Quran greatly emphasizes reasoning and reflection, even telling people not to follow what they have no knowledge of. It urges people to observe the creation of animals, heavens, and earth to understand God's greatness and wisdom. The worst creatures to God are the deaf and dumb who do not reason. Imam al-Kadhimi said God has two proofs for people: the apparent proof (prophets, Imams) and the inner proof (human intellects). Therefore, reason has special authority in Islam, equal to the prophets' words, and the two never contradict. Since reason is validated, and one domain of reason's activity is empirical sciences (which discover nature's secrets through observation/experiment), any certain, definitive conclusion reached by reason/science is credible and followable in Islam's view. The Prophet made seeking knowledge obligatory for every Muslim, and in another narration said to seek knowledge even if in China—indicating empirical sciences. Therefore, Islam strongly emphasizes rationality and learning empirical sciences. If science were inherently contradictory to religion, such emphasis would be incorrect. Hence, scientific findings cannot contradict religious teachings. One aspect of the Quran's miracle is its scientific miracle.

(In contrast, the Christian Bible contains doctrines incompatible with reason/science, likely due to distortion, as even some Christian thinkers admit.)

****Types of Relationship Between Science and Religion****

1. ****Science and Religion as Two Modes of Expressing One Reality:**** Scientific and religious statements express common truths about the world in two different ways. Any apparent disagreement, if analyzed, shows agreement. (E.g., Quran's poetic allusion to Earth's motion; scientists' empirical proof). Galileo saw nature and scripture as two congruent guides to God.
2. ****Science as Confirmer of Religion:**** Scientific theories support religious teachings. As science discovers more of nature's secrets, humans better appreciate the universe's complexity and thus the wise, powerful God. Also, secrets of some religious teachings are uncovered with

scientific progress (e.g., Quran's mention of paired creation of all things, including plants; discovered later by science. Mention of conservation laws discovered later by physics).

3. ****Science and Religion as Complementary:**** They complement each other, each examining a specific aspect of truth. Complete understanding requires both. Science answers "what and how" based on observable factors; religion deals with "why and for what purpose." Philosopher Donald MacKay saw science seeking causes, theology seeking meaning. Scholar Morteza Motahhari believed science and faith complement each other: science gives light/power, faith gives love/hope/warmth; science makes tools, faith gives destination; science is ability, faith is good willing; science is outer revolution, faith inner revolution.

* ****Note:**** Sometimes religion also addresses causes of events. If conflict arises between religious and scientific explanations, the solution is clear: scientific theories are not certain, and religious texts allow some interpretation. If conflict occurs, either the religious interpretation is incorrect, or the scientific theory is not definitive but treated as such.

4. ****Incompatibility Between Science and Religion:**** Religion and science are at least in some cases incompatible; both cannot be accepted. (E.g., geocentrism vs. heliocentrism; evolution vs. special creation).

* ****Response:**** As noted, the Christian Bible is distorted, and its integration with Aristotelian cosmology created false conflicts. The uncorrupted Quran indicates Earth's motion and sphericity, compatible with heliocentrism. So, Earth's fixity is not a definitive religious theory. Regarding evolution, it remains a hypothesis not definitively proven, with counter-evidence. The religious creation text also allows various interpretations. Thus, conflict can be resolved. In Christianity, reactions varied: some fundamentalists defended literal Bible meaning; some found theology compatible with evolution; some adopted instrumentalism (theories are just useful tools, not representing reality); some sided with science and abandoned religion. Given the non-certainty of scientific theories, abandoning religion is not correct, especially when prophets challenge with miracles that give certainty about divine revelation.

5. ****Complete Separation of the Domains of Science and Religion:**** Their domains are completely separate; no conflict arises because conflict requires a common subject with incompatible judgments. Here, subject, method, and aim differ.

* ****Sub-views:****

* ****Neo-Orthodoxy (e.g., Karl Barth):**** Theology deals with God's revelation in Christ; science deals with nature. Different subjects, methods (revelation vs. reason), and aims (preparation to meet God vs. knowing nature's patterns). No commonality, thus no conflict.

* ****Existentialism (e.g., Kierkegaard, Buber):**** Religion's subject is personal, ethical, existential truths ("I-Thou" relationship with God). Science's subject is material objects and their function ("I-It" relationship). Aims and methods (personal involvement vs. detached reason) differ entirely.

* ****Linguistic Analysis (e.g., Wittgenstein):**** Science and religion have different "language games" with distinct logic and criteria. Scientific language is for prediction/control; religious language for worship/peace.

* ****Kantian View:**** Kant divided reason into theoretical and practical. Science belongs to theoretical reason (limited to experience); religion belongs to practical reason (morality). They cannot conflict.

****Critique of Separation Views:**** A major flaw is that proponents judge religion without examining its various dimensions. For example, since many of God's attributes are known through reason, and Islam in some cases invites reflection on natural phenomena to understand divine wisdom, this shows that in some cases, cosmology and anthropology are common subjects for religion and science. Thus, they share subject and method in some areas.

Existentialism limits religion to individual matters, neglecting its social dimension. Religion, contrary to existentialism, asks followers to choose religion through reasoning.

Some separation views entail abandoning the apparent/real meaning of religious texts, which is against religious teachings.

****Conclusion:**** Among the various relationships, the first three views (two expressions, confirmation, complementarity) have more agreement.

Part 3: Sources of Understanding Islam

****a) The Quran and the Prophetic Tradition (Sunnah)****

****b) Reason and Its Role in Understanding Religion****

****c) The Finality of Prophethood (Khatamiyyah)****

****d) The Methodology for Understanding Religion****

****Introduction: A Brief Definition of Islam****

Before discussing the sources of Islamic knowledge, let's briefly define Islam.

****Definition of Islam:****

Linguistically, the word "Islam" means submission and surrender. The Quran calls the religion it invites people to "Islam" because its overarching program is the submission of humanity to divine commandments.

Abraham (AS) was the first to name this religion "Islam" and its followers "Muslims." Undoubtedly, the religion with God is *Islam*, which has manifested throughout history in different forms of divine law (Shari'ah).

In Islamic terminology, Islam is the final and most complete divine law that God has revealed for the guidance of all humanity forever. The laws of such a religion align with human nature and intellect and respond to all human needs—individual, social, and spiritual. By following the directives of such a religion, people can achieve spiritual and material perfection and attain happiness in this life and the hereafter.

a) The Quran and the Prophetic Tradition (Sunnah)

****The Quran****

The Quran is a gift, a mercy, and a healing remedy that God, out of His grace, has bestowed upon humanity. It is a treasure whose benefits are endless and a light that never fades. In the expanse of human religious culture, no heavenly book possesses the level of infallibility, authenticity, eloquence, precision, historical credibility, and truthfulness as the Quran. This book, revealed by God for human guidance, is also protected by Him from any distortion or alteration so it can fulfill its mission of guiding people from darkness to light. The language of the Quran, despite being miraculous, is the conventional language of reason, as its audience is all human beings.

Although the apparent meanings of the Quran are clear, it does not mean the Quran requires no interpretation. In other words, the Quran is a "weighty word." While its language is rational and its words are clear Arabic, it does not mean everyone benefits from this divine book equally. Quranic knowledge has levels, and each level is attained by specific groups according to their capacity. As narrated from Imam Husayn and Imam Sadiq (AS): "God has expressed His knowledge in the Quran in four ways: explicit statements, allusions, subtleties, and profound truths. The explicit statements are for the general public, the allusions are for the elite, the subtleties are for the saints (awliya'), and the profound truths are for the prophets."

Thus, the Quran has both an apparent (zahir) and a deeper, inner (batin) dimension. However, it's crucial to note that the inner meaning never contradicts the apparent one; rather, it deepens it. Therefore, interpreting the meanings and teachings from both levels is the work of qualified, knowledgeable, and pious interpreters.

God has placed the responsibility of explaining the Quran upon the Prophet (SAW) and then the infallible Imams (AS). The Imams, in turn, have entrusted this important duty to committed, pious scholars and interpreters. Competent interpreters, due to their mastery of the Quran and the infallible tradition and based on correct methodology, can derive benefit from this divine book.

The Quran is the eternal miracle of the Prophet Muhammad (SAW), which will forever remain the book of guidance for humanity. This book itself proves his prophethood, as the claim of prophethood was accompanied by it:

1. It challenged people to produce something like it.
2. People were unable to meet this challenge.
3. Over fifteen centuries, the enemies of Islam have spared no effort to strike at Islam, even accusing the Prophet (SAW) of magic and madness, but they have never been able to successfully challenge the Quran. Today, despite intensified attacks by global arrogance against Islam and the Prophet, they have not been able to answer the Quran's open challenge, which is the best proof of its miraculous nature.

The Quran is superior to all the miracles of previous prophets because it keeps pace with time to convey its message to the world and establish proof for all future generations. Simply put, unlike the miracles of other prophets, which occurred before a limited audience at a specific time, this miracle is always available to people. Since the Prophet of Islam is the final prophet with a permanent mission, his miracle must also be permanent and eternal—and so it is.

****Dimensions of the Quran's Inimitability (I'jaz)****

The Quran's miraculous nature is multi-faceted. Here are some key dimensions:

****1. Eloquence and Rhetorical Excellence (Fasahat wa Balaghat):****

The Quran was revealed in Arabic and uses the Arabic alphabet, but the structure of its phrases is in the most eloquent and expressive manner. God has used the most beautiful words and captivating compositions to convey His message in the best possible way. When the most eloquent Arab poets and linguists heard the divine verses from the Prophet, they encountered a new kind of speech—neither poetry nor ordinary prose—with a melody more beautiful than poetry and expression more effective than prose. The verses were so delightful and awe-inspiring that they attracted any fair-minded listener. Disbelievers warned their youth against listening to it or made noise during its recitation so others wouldn't hear it. Renowned Arab literary figures like Walid ibn al-Mughirah acknowledged its inimitability, admitting they had heard nothing like it from humans or jinn.

****2. Inimitability in Divine Knowledge and Content:****

The Quran contains knowledge and sciences of such breadth and depth that they have illuminated the thoughts of thinkers since its revelation. It encompasses profound theological concepts, the most just legal and penal codes, the best individual and social laws, the wisest devotional practices, the most valuable moral instructions and advice, the most accurate historical points, and the most effective educational methods. As human sciences advance, the truth and secrets of these teachings become more apparent. The existence of such lofty knowledge in the Quran, especially as expressed by an "unlettered" (ummi) individual who did not formally study, indicates a divine origin. The Prophet recited these verses before his tribesmen and people who knew him well, and no one denied them. Their silence in the face of such a claim is decisive proof of his truthfulness.

****3. Internal Consistency and Absence of Contradiction:****

The Quran is a collection of verses revealed over 23 years in diverse situations. However, this variety of circumstances never affected its style of expression or the consistency of its content. This harmony and lack of contradiction is itself proof of its miraculous nature. If the Prophet had presented the Quran's content from himself without connection to revelation, discrepancies in style and contradictions in content would naturally be evident because: a) Human knowledge and intellectual output evolve over time, and such development would be apparent in an individual's speech over 23 years. b) A person's inner states (joy, sorrow, excitement, calm) affect their manner of speech. The speech of an ordinary person cannot be uniform and harmonious across all these states. The Quran itself points to this aspect: "Do they not reflect upon the Quran? If it had been from [any] other than God, they would have found within it much contradiction." (Quran 4:82)

****4. Inimitability Regarding Secrets of Creation:****

The Quran unveils secrets of cosmic laws, nature, and celestial bodies in numerous verses. Discovering such secrets for an unlettered individual is only possible through divine revelation. While the Quran is not a scientific textbook, when it mentions natural secrets, it is for educational, ethical, and theological purposes, as it is a book of human guidance and education. Due to the scientific context of its revelation, the Quran presents these secrets cautiously, through allusion and metaphor, as understanding scientific truths was difficult for people of that era. However, gradually, with scientific progress and the discovery of nature's secrets, the

scientific truths of the Quran become apparent. Examples include its subtle references to the Earth's motion (using the metaphor of a cradle), the general principle of pairs in creation (including plants), and the concept of invisible forces holding up the heavens (akin to gravitational forces).

****5. Inimitability in Predicting Future Events:****

The Quran gives news of important future events, all of which later occurred exactly as described. These predictions, coupled with the claim of prophethood, indicate they originated from the realm of revelation. It is possible for some individuals to predict future events through spiritual discipline, but not with certainty and complete detail, and they do not claim prophethood. Examples include: a) The prediction that humans and jinn would be unable to produce anything like the Quran—a challenge that remains unmet after fourteen centuries. b) The prediction of the Romans' victory over the Persians within a few years, which came true. c) The prediction of the Prophet's ultimate victory over the polytheists of Mecca, made at a time when it seemed impossible. d) The promise of the Prophet's return to Mecca after his migration, which was fulfilled years later.

****The Quran's Protection from Distortion (Tahreef):****

Undoubtedly, the heavenly books of previous prophets, like the Torah and the Gospel, have been distorted and are not available in the exact form received by Moses and Jesus (AS). The Quran and historical/ rational evidence prove this. The question is whether the Quran, free from any distortion or alteration, remains in its original form.

Undoubtedly, unlike previous scriptures, the Quran is preserved from any distortion. If any addition or omission had occurred, it would no longer be inimitable in style and content, and others could produce something like it. Thus, the same reasoning that proves the Quran's inimitability also proves its protection from distortion. Divine wisdom also necessitates that a book meant to guide people forever remains intact to fulfill its mission.

****Some Reasons for the Quran's Protection from Distortion:****

1. History testifies that Muslims paid exceptional attention to teaching, memorizing, and writing down the Quran. In just one battle, the number of martyrs who were memorizers (hafiz) of the Quran reached seventy. Given this immense dedication by Muslims to preserve the Quran—even its exact number of verses, words, and chapters—how could such a widely recited, memorized, and cherished book be distorted? Any attempt would have been recorded in history, and Muslims would have reacted strongly to prevent it. The consensus (ijma') of Muslims on the absence of distortion is itself proof.
2. God Himself has taken responsibility for preserving the Quran: "Indeed, it is We who sent down the Quran and indeed, We will be its guardian." (Quran 15:9) In another verse: "Falsehood cannot approach it from before it or from behind it; [it is] a revelation from a [Lord who is] Wise and Praiseworthy." (Quran 41:42)
3. Imam Ali (AS) and the other infallible Imams (AS) never spoke about the distortion of the Quran. On the contrary, they always called people to reflect upon and act according to the Quran. If distortion had occurred, the infallible Imams would never have remained silent.

The Prophetic Tradition (Sunnah)

In addition to receiving and conveying divine revelation, the Prophet of Islam (SAW) was also responsible for explaining and clarifying the divine verses, as not all the details of divine laws are mentioned in the Quran. For example, the phrase "establish prayer" (aqim al-salah) is repeated in the Quran, but the number of prayer units (rak'at) is not specified. Some verses also require correct interpretation. Therefore, the Prophet, through his words and actions, explained the details of the verses and interpreted those related to rulings. For instance, in explaining prayer details, he said: "Pray as you see me praying."

After the Prophet, the duty of explaining the divine verses falls upon the infallible Imams (AS).

Definition of Sunnah:

Linguistically, Sunnah means method or way, used in both the Quran and narrations. In Islamic terminology, Sunnah refers to all the sayings, actions, and tacit approvals of the infallible guides (the Prophet and Imams). "Tacit approval" means that if someone performed an act or said something in the presence of an infallible Imam, and the Imam did not express any opposition or chose silence, this implies his confirmation, as it would be obligatory for him to prohibit anything illegitimate.

Thus, what the Prophet and infallible Imam said or did in explaining the divine verses is called "Sunnah," which is one of the sources of Shi'a jurisprudence.

The Authority (Hujjiyyah) of the Sunnah:

From the Shi'a perspective, the Prophet (SAW) and the Imams (AS) are infallible and free from error, mistake, and sin. Therefore, their sayings, actions, and approvals are authoritative evidence. Some proofs for the authority of the Sunnah include:

- * The Quran states: "And We revealed to you the message that you may make clear to the people what was sent down to them..." (Quran 16:44). The fact that explaining the verses is entrusted to the Prophet is proof of the authority of his speech.
- * "O you who have believed, obey Allah and obey the Messenger and those in authority among you..." (Quran 4:59). From the Shi'a view, "those in authority" refers to the infallible Imams, whose obedience is equated with obedience to God.
- * "...And whatever the Messenger has given you, take; and what he has forbidden you, refrain from..." (Quran 59:7). According to this verse, what the Prophet says in his capacity of "explaining divine rulings" is part of divine revelation and is authoritative.
- * In the famous Hadith al-Thaqalayn (the Two Weighty Things), the Prophet (SAW) said: "I am leaving among you two weighty things: the Book of Allah and my progeny, my household. As long as you hold fast to them, you will never go astray." Here, the Prophet equates his household with the Quran.
- * In the Hadith al-Safinah (the Ship), the Prophet (SAW) said: "Behold! My household among you is like the ship of Noah; whoever boards it is saved, and whoever turns away from it is drowned." This also establishes the authority of the Sunnah of the infallible Imams.

b) Reason and Its Role in Understanding Religion

****The Status of Reason:****

Linguistically, "aql" (reason) means to restrain or prevent. It is the faculty that distinguishes humans from other animals, enabling them to think, reason, and distinguish between good and bad, right and wrong. This faculty exists, to varying degrees, in all humans.

****Types of Reason:****

Reason can be divided into "theoretical reason" and "practical reason." This is not two separate reasons but one faculty with two applications. Theoretical reason deals with understanding matters that do not directly necessitate action (e.g., understanding the impossibility of a contradiction). Practical reason deals with understanding matters that directly necessitate action (e.g., understanding the inherent goodness of justice or the evil of oppression).

****The Authority of Reason:****

The authority of the definitive, certain judgments of both theoretical and practical reason is intrinsic; it does not need to derive its authority from another source. (This applies to self-evident or conclusively demonstrated rational judgments, not to non-evident or speculative ones). It is through reason that we recognize the validity of other sources of evidence.

Denying the authority of reason's certain judgments leads to absolute skepticism. For example, if someone denies the impossibility of contradiction, the need of an effect for a cause, or the goodness of justice, they would end up denying everything.

Shi'a theologians maintain that reason, independent of religious law, can perceive the goodness or evil of certain actions (like justice being good and oppression being evil). In contrast, the Ash'arites believe no action is inherently good or evil; good and evil stem solely from God's command or prohibition. The Shi'a argument is that if goodness and evil were not inherent, religion itself could not be established, as we would have no basis to trust a prophet's claims or statements.

The Quran and narrations also clearly testify to rational goodness and evil. For example: "Indeed, Allah orders justice and good conduct and giving to relatives and forbids immorality and bad conduct and oppression. He admonishes you that perhaps you will be reminded." (Quran 16:90). The verse indicates that God commands based on what is known as just and good. Imam Sadiq (AS) also said: "Through reason, the servants recognized their Creator... and through it, they distinguished the good from the evil."

Therefore, reason, independent of religious law, discerns the goodness and evil of some actions. From a religious perspective, these certain rational judgments are authoritative, making reason one of the sources of religion, sometimes called the "inner proof" (al-hujjah al-batinah).

****The Relationship Between Reason and Religion:****

This is a significant issue in religious studies. Two main perspectives are Fideism (faith-based) and Rationalism.

- * ****Fideism**** views religion as a realm where rational activity is ineffective. Adherents say believers should accept religious beliefs based on faith, not reason.

- * ****Rationalism**** holds that religious beliefs can be evaluated by rational standards and believes in a harmony between religion and reason.

From the Islamic perspective, reason and religion are two divine gifts bestowed upon humanity that together, not separately, lead to eternal salvation. Reason confirms religion, and religion confirms reason. The Quran was revealed for contemplation, and it considers those who do not think as the worst of creatures. The Imams referred to reason as the "inner proof" and stated that one who has reason has religion.

Therefore, a reciprocal and close relationship exists between reason and religion. No Islamic sect has completely rejected reason and intellect; the difference lies in the scope of reason's function. Even traditionalists (Ahl al-Hadith), who prohibit rational discussion in religious matters, used their reason to accept religion in the first place.

From the Shi'a view, just as we need reason to accept religion and prove its fundamental principles, we must also use reason to derive religious rulings and distinguish divine laws from others. Hence, definitive rational judgments are considered a source for understanding divine law.

In the Christian world, due to the non-rational nature of core doctrines (like the Trinity, divinity of Christ, original sin, and transubstantiation), Christian theologians had little choice but to adopt a fideistic approach, saying "believe in order to understand." Some fideists consider faith contrary to reason, while others say it is beyond reason, not against it. Figures like Paul and Tertullian explicitly disparaged philosophy and reason. Others, like Kierkegaard, believed genuine religious faith appears when reason reaches its limit.

While rationalist trends also exist in Christianity (e.g., Thomas Aquinas), even they resorted to fideism regarding certain doctrines like the Trinity.

In conclusion, as the Quran indicates, a religion incompatible with reason is a distorted one. The true, undistorted religion is consistent with reason, as is the case with Islam.

c) The Finality of Prophethood (Khatamiyyah)

The finality of prophethood is one of the essential doctrines of Islam. It means the chain of divine prophets ends with the Prophet of Islam, and no prophet will come after him. The Quran and numerous, widely transmitted (mutawatir) narrations explicitly emphasize this.

****Finality in the Quran:****

The Quran explicitly and implicitly points to the finality of the Prophet Muhammad (SAW). For example: ***"Muhammad is not the father of [any] one of your men, but [he is] the Messenger of Allah and the seal of the prophets."** (Quran 33:40). The word "Khatam" (seal) comes from the root meaning "to conclude or end something." Classical linguists explain that its primary meaning is to bring something to an end; sealing something with a stamp is derived from this, as sealing is done after finishing something. Islamic narrations also interpret "Khatam" as "the end." For instance, Imam Ali (AS) interpreted the verse as meaning: "There is no prophet after him."

Some have tried to interpret "Khatam" as "ornament" (meaning the ornament of the prophets), but this is linguistically incorrect. There is no contextual indication in the verse to suggest a metaphorical meaning.

Another potential objection is that the verse says "seal of the *prophets*," not of *messengers*. The response clarifies the terminology: Every *rasul* (messenger) is a *nabi* (prophet), but not every *nabi* is a *rasul*. A *nabi* receives revelation and knows the unseen but may not be tasked with conveying a new law or book. A *rasul* has the additional roles of conveyance, bringing a new law, or a new scripture. Thus, sealing *nubuwwah* (prophethood) also seals *risalah* (messengership).

Other verses also imply finality:

* ***"This day I have perfected for you your religion and completed My favor upon you and have approved for you Islam as religion."** (Quran 5:3). This indicates the religion is complete, and no new revelation is needed for its perfection.

* ***"And indeed, [O Muhammad], you receive the Quran from One Wise and Knowing."** (Quran 27:6). The emphasis is on the Quran as the final revelation.

* ***"And We have not sent you except as a bringer of good tidings and a warner to all mankind..."** (Quran 34:28). The universality and permanence of his mission imply it is for all future generations until the end of time.

****Finality in Islamic Narrations:****

Many narrations explicitly emphasize this. Examples include:

* ***Hadith of Manzilah:** The Prophet (SAW) told Imam Ali (AS): "Are you not satisfied that you are to me as Aaron was to Moses, except that there will be no prophet after me?"

* A narration where the Prophet (SAW) compared himself to the final brick that completes a beautiful building, stating he is that final brick and the prophets have been sealed through him.

* Narrations from Imam Ali (AS) and others stating God sent Muhammad (SAW) to fulfill His promise and complete prophethood.

****Objections and Responses Regarding Finality:****

1. ****Objection: Finality as the End of the "Age of Instinct" (Iqbal Lahori's View):**** Some, like Muhammad Iqbal, interpreted finality as the end of guidance based on pure instinct/revelation and the dawn of the age where empirical reason replaces revelation.

* ****Response:**** This view implies humans no longer need revelation, which is incorrect. Revelation came precisely because reason alone cannot access certain spiritual truths. The Quran itself was revealed for contemplation. Reason and revelation are two complementary proofs (outward and inward), one cannot replace the other. Many great intellectuals have accepted revealed guidance.

2. ****Objection: Finality as the End of "Personal Authority":**** Some claim finality means ending the era where a prophet's word was accepted without argument based on personal authority.

* ****Response:**** The Prophet's speech, as divine revelation, is itself proof and light. The Quran constantly invites people to think, reflect, and use reason. It challenges people to find contradictions in it. Its arguments, while not always in formal philosophical form, are rational and aligned with human nature. The authority of the Prophet's speech is established through rational proof of his infallibility.

3. ****Objection: Incompatibility with the Authority of the Infallible Imams:**** Some argue that if the Imams' speech is infallible and authoritative, it sits in the rank of revelation, contradicting finality.

* ****Response:**** All Muslims believe in the authority of the Quran and the definitive Sunnah of the Prophet. In the Hadith al-Thaqalayn, the Prophet paired his progeny (Ahl al-Bayt) with the Quran, stating adherence to both prevents misguidance. The Quran also declares the purification of the Ahl al-Bayt from all impurity. Therefore, their speech and actions are authoritative based on the Prophet's own definitive teachings. There is no contradiction between finality and the guiding authority of the Imams as explainers and protectors of the message.

d) The Methodology for Understanding Religion

****The Comprehensibility of Religion:****

Religion is a set of teachings revealed by God for human guidance, the last and most complete of which is Islam. No heavenly book enjoys the historical credibility and authority of the Quran. The Quran is a clear light, a manifest book, a guide for people, and an explanation of everything. Such descriptions imply it must be comprehensible, clear, and understandable. The Quran criticizes those who turn away from hearing its verses and pondering their meanings, which itself indicates its understandability. The Quran states: "And We have certainly made the Quran easy for remembrance, so is there any who will remember?" (Quran 54:17)

However, the comprehensibility of the Quran does not mean all people benefit from it equally. It is like a shoreless ocean; everyone can benefit according to their capacity. The levels of understanding are complementary and never contradict the apparent meaning.

****The Need for a Methodological Approach:****

Although religion is understandable, this understanding must be methodical. It does not mean anyone can refer to a verse or narration without the necessary logical tools for understanding the Quran and derive an Islamic ruling, or approach the Quran with a specific preconception and impose their view on it. To interpret the Quran correctly, one must follow a sound methodology based on observing the following:

1. ****Knowledge of Arabic Grammar:**** The first foundation for understanding the Quran is knowledge of Arabic grammar to properly distinguish subject from object, etc.
2. ****Knowledge of Quranic Lexicon:**** Understanding the meanings of Quranic words and terms as used in the era of revelation, not necessarily their modern or assumed meanings. Specialized lexicons are essential.
3. ****Interpreting the Quran by the Quran (Tafsir al-Qur'an bi al-Qur'an):**** Since the Quran presents itself as an explainer of all things, it certainly explains itself. To understand one verse, other relevant verses should be consulted. Imam Ali (AS) said: "Some parts of the Quran speak with other parts, revealing their meaning, and some parts testify to others."
4. ****Referring to Authentic Narrations (Hadith):**** Understanding some verses is impossible without referring to authentic Islamic narrations, as they provide the details and qualifications for general Quranic commands (e.g., details of prayer, fasting).
5. ****Considering the Occasion of Revelation (Asbab al-Nuzul):**** Knowing the historical context or questions that prompted the revelation of a verse clarifies its meaning, though the general principle of the verse extends beyond the specific incident.
6. ****Awareness of the Historical Context of Revelation:**** Knowing the social and cultural conditions of pre-Islamic and early Islamic Arabia helps in understanding verses that critique specific practices.
7. ****Distinguishing Meccan and Medinan Verses:**** Verses revealed before the Hijrah (in Mecca) often focus on beliefs and theological concepts, while those revealed after (in Medina) often focus on laws and social rulings. This distinction aids understanding.
8. ****Avoiding Preconceptions (Tafsir bi al-Ra'y):**** The interpreter must approach the Quran without preconceived notions or imposing personal opinions to reach its intended meanings. One must be a student in the presence of the Quran. The "interpretation based on personal opinion" is strongly warned against in Islamic tradition.

Furthermore, understanding Quranic verses and narrations must not contradict sound reason. For example, the interpretations of groups like the Jabriyah (predestination extremists) or Mujassimah (anthropomorphists), which conflict with reason and other Quranic verses, are not acceptable.

****The Theory of "Evolutive Understanding of Religion":****

Some thinkers, influenced by figures like Alfred Firmin Loisy, propose that while religion itself is fixed and eternal, our *understanding* of it evolves and is subject to growth and change like other human knowledge.

****Critique of this Theory:****

1. If religious knowledge is inherently incomplete and unstable, then this very theory, being a type of religious knowledge, must also be incomplete and unstable. Why should we accept an unstable theory?
2. Not all human knowledge is in constant flux. Foundational rational principles (like the law of non-contradiction) and many established religious rulings (like the obligation of the five daily prayers or fasting in Ramadan) have remained constant and agreed upon by Muslims since the beginning.
3. The claim that all fields of knowledge are so interconnected that a change in one necessitates a change in religious knowledge is not proven by reason or experience. Discovering a taller mountain does not change mathematical equations or the number of prayer units.
4. Many religious teachings and rulings have remained fixed since the dawn of Islam with consensus among Muslims.

Therefore, the theory that *all* religious understanding is variable and evolutive is not correct.

Part Four: Imamate and Guardianship (Wilayah)

A) The Meaning of Imamate and Wilayah

The term "Imam" means leader or guide, derived from the root "أَمَّ" meaning to intend or to turn towards, as people turn to the Imam with specific intent and attention. In the Quran, the word "Imam" applies to both righteous and unrighteous leaders:

* "On the Day when We shall summon every people with their Imam (leader)." (Quran 17:71)

In the terminology of Shi'a theologians, the Imam is the one who, as the successor to the Messenger of God, holds a divinely appointed, comprehensive authority over all religious and worldly affairs of the Islamic community. Based on this definition, the Imam holds all the positions and ranks of prophethood except for receiving revelation (wahy). Therefore, the Imam must possess specific characteristics:

1. Be appointed by God.
2. Possess *'Ismaḥ* (infallibility – being free from sin and error). Without infallibility, he could not gain the people's trust, be a role model, or find a place in their hearts. Therefore, the Imam must be free from all slips and errors so as not to lead people astray.
3. Possess a deep and extensive knowledge of all religious matters so that in explaining these matters and solving the scientific and religious problems of the Islamic community, he is not dependent on others. Without such extensive knowledge, the Imam could not fill the void created by the Prophet's absence in the Islamic community.

Sunni theologians disagree with this Shi'a definition. They view Imamate as a conventional, non-divine position that is delegated to an individual through the choice of the people, particularly the Muhajirun and Ansar, or the scholars of *Ahl al-Hal wal-'Aqd* (those who loosen and bind). Some Sunni thinkers even hold that an Imam can assume leadership of the community by force and power, and even if he is immoral or a drunkard, these impurities do not necessitate his removal.

****Historical Emergence of the Dispute over Imamate****

Hadiths, narrations, and Islamic history indicate that the dispute over the issue of Imamate and the succession of the Messenger of God reached its peak after the Prophet's passing in the Saqifah. However, it was also a topic during the Prophet's own lifetime. Some during the Prophet's time whispered and discussed about the leadership of the Muslims after his demise. Even some, like the delegation from Ta'if, made their acceptance of Islam conditional upon the matter of Imamate and Caliphate after the Prophet being delegated to them. When they received a negative response from the Prophet, they refused to accept Islam. Furthermore, whenever the Prophet left Medina for travel, defense, or war, he would appoint a successor. The repetition of this act during the Prophet's life stimulated the Muslims' curiosity to think and express opinions on the issue of Imamate and succession. Therefore, based on the Shi'a view,

it cannot be said that attention to the vital issue of Imamate began after the Prophet's demise; rather, Muslims during his lifetime also thought about this matter to varying degrees. Shi'a thinkers also argue based on definitive evidence that the Imamate and succession of Amir al-Mu'minin Ali (upon him be peace) was established during the Prophet's own time, and he emphasized this matter repeatedly.

****The Scope of Discussion on Imamate****

Some scholars believe the dispute over the Prophet's Imamate and succession is a historical issue whose time has passed, and discussing it scientifically is no longer beneficial. From the Shi'a perspective, this belief is incorrect because Imamate has various historical, scientific, social, and religious dimensions. Discussing Imamate is not merely a historical issue whose time has passed; rather, it is a discussion about the method of Islamic governance, which is one of the most essential topics of our time. Since religion and Islamic laws are eternal, discussing the characteristics of the executor of these laws – the Imam and leader of the Islamic community – is also eternal. Considering the importance of the position of Imamate, the ruler and executor of Islamic laws must be appointed based on divine designation (*nass*), not through the consensus or consultation of the community. If we accept that the position of Imamate is one of appointment, then the execution of the laws of the Shari'ah must be entrusted to individuals who have been given the responsibility of leading the community by God.

During the occultation (*ghaybah*), when the last Imam appointed by God and the Prophet resides behind the veil of occultation due to unfavorable conditions, this question arises: What is the plan of Islam and the Imams for executing the eternal laws of religion in this period? In the period of occultation, must the Islamic ruler also be appointed by the Prophet and the Imams, or can the people choose anyone as an Imam? From this, it can be concluded that discussing Imamate is a discussion about the method of Islamic governance in all eras.

Another dimension of Imamate, from the Shi'a perspective, is the explanation and elaboration of principles and teachings, the clarification of religious laws and branches, and arbitrating between the different thoughts that arise among Muslims. These perspectives are undoubtedly derived from the words and tradition (*Sunnah*) of the Prophet of Islam. Therefore, the scholarly authority (*marja'iyah*) of the infallible Imams is not only authoritative for their contemporaries but will be a proof (*hujjah*) for all future generations, resolving many intellectual, social, economic, etc., problems.

Discussion about Imamate does not contradict the harmony and unity of the Islamic community, as in these discussions, more attention is paid to commonalities, and disputed issues are raised in a scientific and friendly atmosphere, free from prejudice. Engaging in scientific discussions, hearing different views, and following the best of them is recommended by the Quran. The goal of rapprochement (*taqrib*) between Islamic schools of thought is to bring ideas closer, practice tolerance, emphasize common points, and achieve unity and cohesion of the Islamic community against its enemies. Based on this perspective, the Sheikh of Al-Azhar, Sheikh Mahmud Shaltut, officially considered following the Shi'a school (Ja'fari) permissible for Sunni brothers.

****The Need for an Imam****

The Prophet of Islam had three responsibilities: receiving and conveying divine revelation, explaining the revelation, and leading the Islamic community. After the Prophet's demise, the era of revelation ended, so his first responsibility concluded. However, the other two positions remained necessary for guiding the Islamic community: establishing a government to implement and realize Islamic spiritual, economic, and social laws, and explaining the revelation after the Prophet. From the Shi'a perspective, after the Prophet, God appointed the infallible Imams with divinely-given knowledge so they could be the explainers of divine revelation – in other words, the reference point, protectors of religion, and administrators of the Islamic community.

The appointment of Imams after the Prophet is noteworthy for the following reasons:

1. During his 23 years of prophethood, the Prophet did not have the opportunity to explain all the details of divine laws because, firstly, many issues and laws did not become relevant during his time, and thus questions about them were not raised. Secondly, during the thirteen years of his prophethood in Mecca, only a few believed. In the last ten years of his life in Medina, many wars occurred, and thus conditions were not prepared for him to elaborate on divine laws in detail. Therefore, after the Prophet, the Islamic community needed knowledgeable individuals to turn to for these matters.
2. After the Prophet, various sects like the Mu'tazilah, Khawarij, Murji'ah, Ash'aris, and Shi'a emerged, each substantiating their beliefs with the Quran and interpreting divine verses according to their own beliefs – undoubtedly, only one of these interpretations was correct. Therefore, there must be individuals who can distinguish the correct interpretation from the incorrect and introduce it to the Islamic community so that future adherents to Islam choose the right path.
3. After the Prophet's demise, the fabrication of hadiths attributed to him became rampant. Fabricators entered this field with various motives. Some, like Jewish converts Ka'b al-Ahbar or Wahb ibn Munabbih, introduced Isra'iliyat (Israelite tales) and distortions into Islamic history due to their enmity towards Islam. A group of weak-faithed Muslims, instigated by the caliphs and rulers of the time or motivated by worldly desires or other reasons, also engaged in hadith fabrication. In this matter as well, the presence of an infallible Imam, free from sin and error, is completely felt so that people, by referring to him, can distinguish the true hadith from the false. Furthermore, the Imam must burn the roots of such fabricated and false narrations and baseless ideas and save the community from the harm of these liars.

Therefore, to preserve Islam and prevent the distortion of its luminous face, there must be infallible and knowledgeable Imams to be the criterion of truth and falsehood. Islamic narrations point to the existence of this proof (*hujjah*) after the Prophet's demise. For example, Imam al-Sadiq (upon him be peace) said in narrations: "The earth is never empty of a [infallible] leader, so that if people add something to the religion, he rejects it, and if they omit something, he completes it." ... "God does not leave the earth without a *hujjah*; otherwise, truth would not be distinguished from falsehood."

Hisham ibn al-Hakam, the great theologian and distinguished student of Imam al-Sadiq, also considers the existence of an Imam after the Prophet's demise necessary in two debates. He

argues: Has God placed a proof and guide for the Muslims after the Prophet's passing to resolve any differences among them, or not? If the Quran and the Prophet's hadiths are sufficient to resolve differences, why do you and I differ while we are both pure branches and members of the same tree? In an extensive debate with 'Amr ibn 'Ubayd, the leader of the Mu'tazilah in Basra, Hisham points to the spiritual benefit of the Imam's existence in a pleasant manner, likening the Imam's role to that of intellect in resolving the doubt and error of the senses.

4. Referring to the history of early Islam and considering the conditions of the region and the world at the time of the Prophet's demise further proves the necessity of the appointed nature of Imamate. At the time of his passing, a threefold danger threatened the religion of Islam: the Roman Empire on one side, the Persian Empire on another, and internal hypocrites on the third. With such dangers present, would it be fitting for the Prophet to leave the Islamic community and the religion of Islam, which enemies were lying in wait for from all sides, without a leader? The Prophet undoubtedly knew that Arab life was tribal, and among tribe members, allegiance to tribal chiefs was deeply ingrained. Therefore, leaving the appointment of the leader to such people would cause division and conflict among tribes, and the enemy would benefit from this discord. Thus, appointing the Prophet's successor through his explicit designation (*nass*) seems more correct.

B) Proofs for the Appointment and Infallibility of the Imams

****1. Proofs of Appointment****

In the previous discussion, some rational proofs for the necessity of Imamate were mentioned. Now we point to some Quranic and narrative proofs in this regard.

****Quranic Proofs****

****First: The Verse of Warning (al-Andhar)****

"And warn your closest kindred. And lower your wing to those of the believers who follow you. But if they disobey you, say, 'Indeed, I am disassociated from what you are doing.'" (Quran 26:214-216)

Divine revelation was revealed to the Prophet's heart at Mount Hira, and he was honored with the position of prophethood and messengership. Since Gabriel did not specify the time to begin publicly proclaiming the message, the Prophet avoided public invitation for three years, only attracting a few individuals to his faith through private communication with worthy people. Finally, after three years, the divine command came that the Prophet should begin his public invitation by inviting his close relatives and kin: "Warn your closest kindred of the divine punishment."

The invitation of relatives at the beginning of the public invitation was because unless the close relatives of the divine leader believed in him and followed him collectively, strangers would not respond to his call. A person's close relatives are always aware of his good and bad secrets and traits; their belief is a sign of the claimant of messengership's integrity, and their turning away is a sign of his falsehood. Therefore, the Prophet ordered Ali (upon him be peace) to invite 45 prominent figures from Banu Hashim for a luncheon feast. The guests all accepted the invitation, but after the meal, Abu Lahab, the Prophet's uncle, disrupted the gathering's readiness to hear the Prophet's words with his harsh words, and the gathering ended without result.

The next day, the Prophet decided to arrange another feast and invite everyone except Abu Lahab. Again, after the meal, the Prophet stood before the large gathering of Banu Hashim personalities to invite them to the monotheistic faith and his messengership, beginning: "Truly, a guide never lies to his people. By the God besides whom there is no god! I am His messenger to you and to all people. Know! Just as you sleep, you will die, and just as you wake up [on the Day of Resurrection], you will be resurrected... Who among you will assist me in this matter so that he may be my brother, my executor (*wasi*), and my deputy among you?" The Prophet paused briefly to see which of them would respond positively. At that moment, a silence mixed with awe and fear dominated the gathering, and all had bowed their heads in thought.

Suddenly, Ali (upon him be peace), whose age that day did not exceed sixteen, stood up and said, "O Prophet of God! I will assist you in this matter." He extended his hand to the Prophet to shake hands as a covenant of devotion. The Prophet then ordered Ali to sit down. The Prophet repeated his statement. Again, Ali stood up and declared his readiness. This time also, the Prophet ordered him to sit. The third time, like the two previous times, no one stood up except Ali, and only he declared his support for the Prophet. Then the Prophet placed his hand in Ali's hand and uttered his historic sentence: "O my kinsfolk and relatives! Know that Ali is my brother, my executor, and my successor (*khalifah*) among you." Thus, at the very beginning of the Prophet's messengership, the first executor (*wasi*) of Islam was also appointed. That the Prophet declared both his prophethood and the Imamate of Ali on the same day indicates the distinguished position of Imamate, the inseparability of prophethood and Imamate, and that Imamate always completes the program of messengership.

****Second: The Verse of Guardianship (Wilayah)****

"Your guardian is only Allah, His Messenger, and those who have believed – those who establish prayer and give zakah while bowing in prayer." (Quran 5:55)

Based on numerous hadiths, Sunni and Shi'a exegetes and hadith scholars believe this verse was revealed concerning Ali (upon him be peace), who gave his ring to a beggar while in the state of bowing (*ruku'*) during prayer.

The indication of the verse on Ali's Imamate becomes clear with some preliminaries:

1. Many exegetes and hadith scholars have stated regarding the occasion of revelation of this verse: A beggar entered the mosque and asked for help, but no one gave him anything. The

Imam, while in the state of bowing, pointed with his little finger – on which there was a ring – to the poor man to take the ring off his hand. The poor man took the ring from the Imam's hand and left. When this news reached the Prophet, he requested from God: "Just as You appointed a minister for Moses from his household, O Lord, appoint a minister for me from my household." At that moment, the angel of revelation descended and recited the aforementioned verse for the Prophet.

2. Based on the above, the meaning of "those who have believed – those who establish prayer and give zakah while bowing" in the verse under discussion is specifically Ali ibn Abi Talib (upon him be peace). The term "**wali**" in this verse means guardian, ruler, and authority-holder, which belongs primarily to God, and His Prophet and successor are also entrusted with it by divine grace. If "**wali**" meant friend, helper, or supporter, its restriction (indicated by the particle "**inna**" – meaning "only") to these three would be meaningless, as according to verses, all believers are friends and supporters of each other. The following verse is evidence for this claim: "Whoever takes Allah, His Messenger, and those who have believed as allies – indeed, the party of Allah will be the victorious." (Quran 5:56) This verse is another indication that "**wali**" means guardian, ruler, and authority-holder, as the expression "party of Allah" and overcoming enemies relates to establishing Islamic governance, which indicates a kind of social formation and solidarity for a common goal, not mere friendship.

3. The term "**zakah**" in this verse is not its technical jurisprudential meaning but its general Quranic meaning. The Quran calls any spending in God's way "**zakah**," which includes both obligatory and recommended charity.

4. Some ask: If the verse refers to Amir al-Mu'minin Ali, why are the words "those who have believed," "those who establish," "they give," and "they are bowing" in plural form? The answer is that the Quran frequently uses plural words for an individual. For example, in the verse of *Mubalah* (Quran 3:61), the words "**nisa'**" (our women) and "**anfusanā**" (our souls) are in plural, while Islamic exegetes agree that "our women" refers to Fatimah al-Zahra (upon her be peace) and "our souls" refers to Ali (upon him be peace).

Therefore, the verse clearly indicates that God, His Prophet, and Amir al-Mu'minin Ali have guardianship and authority over the believers and the right to manage their affairs, and any guardianship not centered on them or without their permission is illegitimate.

Third: The Verse of Proclamation (al-Tabligh)

"O Messenger, announce that which has been revealed to you from your Lord, and if you do not, then you have not conveyed His message. And Allah will protect you from the people." (Quran 5:67)

Many Sunni exegetes and hadith scholars, and all Shi'a exegetes and hadith scholars, hold that this verse was revealed concerning the Imamate of Ali (upon him be peace) and the story of Ghadir.

In the final year of the Prophet's life, the Hajj ceremonies concluded with utmost splendor. In these ceremonies, not only the people of Medina but also many of the Prophet's companions from various parts of the Islamic land had the honor of accompanying him. On the 18th of Dhu

al-Hijjah, in a land called Khumm – which was essentially a crossroads where the caravans of pilgrims separated – the Prophet ordered a halt and told his companions that he had a mission from God to convey an important message to them, and if he did not do so, he would not have delivered his message.

Then a pulpit was prepared for the Prophet, and he stood upon it and said to the people: "Soon I will be called to the truth. What do you say about me?" They replied: "We bear witness that you conveyed God's religion to us, gave sincere advice, and strove much for our guidance. May God reward you well." He then said: "Do you bear witness to the oneness of God, my messengership, and the reality of the Day of Resurrection?" All answered positively. Then he said: "I will arrive at the Pool (*al-Hawd*) before you. See how you treat my two weighty successors (*khalifatayn*)." Someone asked: "What are the two weighty successors?" The Prophet replied: "The Book of God and my progeny (*'itrah*). And the Kind and Aware God has informed me that these two will not separate from each other until they meet me at the Pool. Do not precede them, for you will be ruined, and do not fall behind them, for you will also be ruined."

Then he took Ali's hand, raised it, and said: "O people! Who has more authority over the believers than they have over themselves?" They replied: "God and His Messenger know best." The Prophet said: "God is my *mawla* (guardian/master), and I am the *mawla* of the believers, and I have more authority over them than they have over themselves." Then he said three times: "For whomever I am his *mawla*, Ali is his *mawla*." Then he added: "O Lord! Be a friend to whoever befriends Ali, and be an enemy to whoever holds enmity towards Ali. Show kindness to whoever is kind to Ali, and show anger to whoever shows anger to Ali. Help whoever helps Ali, and humiliate whoever humiliates Ali. Make the truth revolve with him and around him." He instructed those present to convey this to those absent.

The Hadith of Ghadir is among the *mutawatir* (massively transmitted) hadiths, narrated by 110 Companions, 89 Followers (*Tabi'in*), and 350 Islamic scholars and hadith narrators from the beginning until now in a continuous chain. Therefore, there is no doubt about its authenticity and validity. Now, what is meant by the Prophet and Ali being "*mawla*"? Many contextual indications testify that the intended meaning is leadership and authority.

Based on this, after delivering the divine message, the Prophet asked those present to convey it to those absent. Then he descended from the pulpit and ordered his companions to congratulate Ali as "Commander of the Faithful" (*Amir al-Mu'minin*). Accordingly, the Imam sat in a tent, and the Prophet's companions entered in groups to congratulate him. Abu Bakr and 'Umar also entered the tent, turned to the Imam, and said: "Congratulations to you, O Ali ibn Abi Talib! Today you have become the *mawla* of every believing man and woman."

The history of Islam shows that the enemies of the Prophet tried various methods to extinguish the light of his divine call, from accusing him of magic to plotting to kill him in his bed. But in all cases, the hand of divine grace was with the Prophet and protected him from the evil plans of the polytheists. Their last hope – especially considering the Prophet had no surviving sons –

was that with his death, this call would be extinguished. But the Prophet, by appointing a competent successor, turned the opponents' hope into despair. With the appointment of such a leader, the blessing of Islam was perfected. Therefore, after the appointment of Ali on the day of Ghadir, the verse of "Perfection of Religion" was revealed: "This day I have perfected for you your religion and completed My favor upon you and have approved for you Islam as religion." (Quran 5:3) Of course, other verses also indicate the Imamate of Ali, but there is no space to mention them in this brief discussion.

****Narrative Proofs****

****First: The Hadith of Position (Manzilah)****

The Prophet of Islam, on various occasions, stated that the position and status of Ali relative to him is like the position and status of Harun (Aaron) relative to Musa (Moses), except that he deprived Ali of one of Harun's positions – prophethood. It is said that when the Prophet learned that the Roman army was preparing to attack Medina, he announced a general mobilization and prepared an army to confront the Roman invasion, gathering them in a camp. At that moment, it was reported to the Prophet that the hypocrites of Medina planned to stage a coup in his absence. To prevent any possible incident, the Prophet seated Ali in his place and ordered him to manage the religious and worldly affairs of the people until his return. When the hypocrites became aware of this and saw their plot foiled, they spread a rumor that relations between Ali and the Prophet had soured and that Ali had fallen out of the Prophet's favor.

The spread of such rumors in the environment of Medina upset Ali's friends. To neutralize this rumor, Ali caught up with the Prophet – who was not far from Medina – and informed him of the matter. At that time, the Prophet uttered his historic sentence: "Are you not satisfied to be to me as Harun was to Musa, except that there is no prophet after me? It is not fitting for me to leave unless you are my successor (*khalifah*)." Based on the Hadith of Manzilah, Ali possesses all the positions of Harun except prophethood. According to the Quran, Harun held the positions of prophethood, ministry (*wizarah*), and succession/caliphate (*khilafah*) of Prophet Musa. Therefore, one of Harun's positions was being the successor of Prophet Musa, and thus obedience to him was obligatory for the Children of Israel after Musa. Based on this, it is also incumbent upon Muslims to follow Ali after the Prophet.

****Second: The Hadith of the Ark (Safinah)****

The Prophet of Islam likened his Household to the Ark of Noah in a narration: "Behold! The likeness of my Household among you is like the Ark of Noah: whoever boards it is saved, and whoever turns away from it is drowned." The Prophet's Household are, like the Ark of Noah, the sole refuge and path to salvation; thus, whoever does not follow them will be misguided.

****The Twelve Imams****

The Prophet did not limit himself to appointing Ali to Imamate; he also gave glad tidings of twelve Imams coming after him, through whom the honor of the religion would be realized. He said in a narration: "Islam will remain honorable until there are twelve caliphs." In another narration, he said: "This religion will remain powerful and invincible until twelve caliphs rule over

it." Undoubtedly, these twelve caliphs and successors of the Prophet – who are the cause of Islam's honor – are only the Shi'a Imams. To prove the twelve infallible Imams, one can first prove the Imamate and infallibility of Ali through the Quran and authentic hadiths, then, by relying on narrations regarding the number of Imams and their names and characteristics, prove the Imamate of the other Imams.

****2. Infallibility of the Imams****

Another characteristic of the Imams is *'Isma*h* (infallibility) or immunity from error and sin. Since they hold all the positions and ranks of prophethood except revelation, the same reasons that necessitated the prophets being immune from error and sin apply to the Imams as well. Therefore, infallibility is not equivalent to prophethood; individuals who possess the rank of infallibility – like Lady Maryam and Lady Fatimah al-Zahra (upon them be peace) – are not prophets.

****Proofs of Infallibility****

****First:**** Since Imamate is a divine position, God has made absolute obedience to the Imams obligatory and equated it with obedience to Himself and His Messenger. Therefore, the command for absolute obedience to them implies the guarantee of their infallibility. In other words, Imamate is a divine covenant, and the divine covenant does not reach the wrongdoers. When Ibrahim (Abraham) requested the position of Imamate for some of his descendants and children, he was met with a conditional response from God: "My covenant does not include the wrongdoers." (Quran 2:124) Furthermore, wrongdoing in its general sense includes wrongdoing to oneself and others, encompassing polytheism and any false belief and sin.

****Second:**** The infallibility of the Ahl al-Bayt can also be proven with the Verse of Purification (al-Tathir). Based on this verse, God's definitive and decisive will is for the purity and cleansing of the Household from **rijs** (impurity) and any filth, of which sin is a prominent example: "Allah intends only to remove from you impurity, O People of the Household, and to purify you with [extensive] purification." (Quran 33:33) This verse clearly indicates that God's creative will (**al-iradah al-takwiniyyah**) is attached to purifying the Prophet's Household from every kind of impurity. The realization of God's will is certain and unavoidable. Absolute purification is concomitant with the rank of infallibility.

****Third:**** Based on the Hadith of Thaqalayn, the Prophet's Household and progeny are equal to the Quran; meaning, just as the Quran is immune from any error and mistake, the Ahl al-Bayt are free from any sin: "I am leaving among you two weighty things: the Book of Allah and my progeny. As long as you hold fast to these two, you will never go astray... And these two will never separate from each other until they meet me at the Pool." It is clear that something holding fast to which is a cause of guidance and prevents misguidance, and never separates from the Quran, must be immune from any error and sin.

****Fourth:**** The Prophet likened his Household to the Ark of Noah; whoever boards it is saved from destruction and the waves of the storm, and whoever turns away from it will drown. Thus,

just as the Ark of Noah was the only means of salvation, holding fast to the Ahl al-Bayt and following them is the only path to salvation and deliverance. Based on this, those who are the means of salvation for the nation are naturally free from error and mistake.

****Love for the Ahl al-Bayt****

Love for the Prophet's Household, emphasized in the Quran and narrations, is among the necessities of the religion. The Quran says in this regard: "Say, 'I do not ask of you for it any payment – only that you show love for [my] near relatives.'" (Quran 42:23) Hadith scholars have narrated from Ibn 'Abbas that when the verse of **mawaddah** (affection) was revealed, the Companions asked: "O Messenger of God! Who are your near relatives whose love is obligatory upon us?" The Prophet said: "Ali, Fatimah, and their two sons." In **mutawatir** narrations from the noble Prophet, it is narrated that whoever loves them loves God, and whoever holds enmity towards them holds enmity towards God.

As for the benefit of loving the Ahl al-Bayt, it must be said that loving a perfect and virtuous human being is itself a ladder for ascent towards perfection. Whenever a person sincerely loves someone, they strive to align themselves with them, do what pleases them, and abandon what harms them. One of the effects of loving the Ahl al-Bayt is practical following of them. Those who only show outward affection but oppose their beloved in action are far from real love. The Prophet's Household are those whom God has purified from every intellectual and spiritual impurity and made them the origin and foundation of every goodness and virtue. Therefore, friendship with the Ahl al-Bayt is in reality friendship with goodness and virtues and following them.

C) Mahdism

From the Shi'a perspective, the infallible Imams are twelve; the first is Ali ibn Abi Talib (upon him be peace), and the last is the Master of the Age (**al-Hujjah ibn al-Hasan al-'Askari**), may God hasten his reappearance. He is, by God's permission, behind the veil of occultation, but on the day when the world is filled with oppression and injustice, by God's permission, he will appear and fill the world with justice and equity and spread Islam throughout the world. Undoubtedly, the realization of this matter is the ultimate goal of the divine prophets, especially the Seal of the Prophets.

Imam Mahdi is the twelfth son of Imam Hasan al-'Askari (upon him be peace), born on the 15th of Sha'ban, 255 AH, in the city of Samarra. His name and **kunya** are the same as the Prophet's. Among his titles are al-Hujjah (the Proof), al-Mahdi (the Guided One), al-Qa'im (the Riser), and Wali al-'Asr (Guardian of the Age). He has two occultations: the minor occultation (**al-ghaybah al-sughra**) and the major occultation (**al-ghaybah al-kubra**). The minor occultation began in 260 AH with the martyrdom of the eleventh Imam. In the period of the minor occultation, the Shi'a communicated with him through four specific deputies. A few days before the death of the fourth deputy, the Master of the Age announced the beginning of the

major occultation, thanking his specific deputies. This period of occultation continues until now. During the major occultation, the Shi'a must refer to the general deputies of the Imam – i.e., knowledgeable and just jurists – for their religious and governmental affairs.

Based on Islamic narrations, belief in the reappearance of Imam Mahdi, the global reformer, is an indisputable matter. The Prophet said: "If only one day remained from the life of the world, God would prolong that day until a man from my progeny rises and fills the earth with justice and equity just as it had been filled with oppression and tyranny." Therefore, the rise and appearance of a man from the Prophet's Household in the end times is a belief of all Muslims, both Shi'a and Sunni. The difference lies in whether Imam Mahdi has been born from a mother and is currently alive, or whether he will be born in the future. Shi'a scholars and some Sunni researchers hold that he was born in 255 AH and is now in occultation, while a group of Sunnis believe he will be born in the future.

****The Quran and Occultation****

From the Quranic perspective, divine allies are of two types: the apparent, whom people know, and the hidden ally (*wali gha'ib*), who is hidden from sight and people do not know him, even though he is among them and aware of their condition. The Quran points to both types in the story of Musa and al-Khidr. Al-Khidr was such that even Prophet Musa did not know him and only recognized him through God's guidance and instruction, benefiting from his knowledge. Similarly, the Master of the Age is an unknown ally who is a source of many blessings for the community. His occultation does not mean his separation from society; rather, based on narrations, he is like the sun behind a cloud – the eyes do not see it, but it gives light and warmth to the people of the earth.

****The Secret of Occultation****

The occultation of the Master of the Age is one of the divine secrets whose exact truth we may not be able to comprehend. Temporary occultations of divine leaders from among the people also have precedent in past nations: Musa ibn 'Imran was absent from his people for forty days, staying at the mount. Prophet Jesus, by divine will, was hidden from the sight of his people such that his enemies could not kill him. Prophet Yunus was also absent from his people for a period.

Generally, when something is proven through *tawatur* (massive transmission) but a person cannot fully comprehend its secret, they should not doubt or deny it. Certainly, the occultation of the Master of the Age is not outside this rule. However, with limited human thought, we can understand the secret of occultation to some extent. God has appointed Imam al-Zaman as the final infallible proof for the realization of a great trial – namely, comprehensive justice and raising the banner of monotheism throughout the world. Undoubtedly, the realization of this important matter requires spiritual preparedness and the flourishing of human intellect and knowledge so that people find the capacity to accept that divine leader. If he were to appear before the appropriate preconditions and groundwork were prepared, the divine proof would depart the world before fulfilling his duty. In narrations, this wisdom is also mentioned; for example, Imam al-Baqir said regarding the occultation of al-Qa'im: "To prevent him from being killed."

Additionally, in some narrations, the issue of divine testing is raised – meaning people in the era of occultation are tested to measure the firmness of their faith and belief.

****The Long Life of Imam Mahdi****

Since Imam Mahdi opened his eyes to the world in 255 AH, over eleven centuries have passed from his noble life. Generally, a long life, considering God's vast and infinite power, is not a complex matter. The God whose will determines the existence and permanence of all creatures can make the life of His proof very long, just as He lengthened the lives of some in previous nations. For example, the Quran states Prophet Nuh's mission as nine hundred and fifty years. Regarding Prophet Yunus, it says: "And had he not been of those who exalt Allah, He would have remained inside its belly until the Day they are resurrected." (Quran 37:143-144) Based on this verse, human life until the Day of Resurrection is possible. On the other hand, scientists believe that if a person avoids some factors like poor nutrition, psychological and emotional stress, etc., they will have a much longer life than the normal lifespan. Therefore, considering the above, the long life of Imam Mahdi is completely acceptable from the perspective of the Quran and science.

****The Time of Imam Mahdi's Reappearance****

This matter is among those things that, like the timing of the establishment of the Day of Resurrection, are known only to God. Therefore, the claims of those who say they know the time of his reappearance cannot be accepted. Of course, in narrations, general signs for his reappearance are mentioned, divided into definite (*hatmi*) and non-definite (*ghayr hatmi*) signs.

****The Meaning of Awaiting (Intizar)****

Based on this, the question arises: What is the duty of Muslims during the occultation? According to narrations from Imam Mahdi, during the occultation, people must refer to knowledgeable and just jurists for their religious and worldly affairs and make their instructions – which are nothing but acting upon the Quran and the Sunnah of the Prophet and the infallible Imams – the guiding principle of their work. They also have the duty to be in a state of awaiting his reappearance and to ask God to hasten his relief (*faraj*).

But what is the meaning of awaiting? Linguistically, "intizar" means "to wait for" and terminologically means keeping an eye on the reappearance of Imam Mahdi. There is a kind of action and effort in awaiting: The person who awaits, while waiting, strives to prepare the ground and environment suitably for the expected individual. Prophet Ya'qub, while awaiting his son Prophet Yusuf, told his sons: "O my sons, go and find out about Joseph and his brother and despair not of relief from Allah." (Quran 12:87) It is also narrated from the Prophet: "The best of deeds of my community is awaiting relief from God, the Almighty." In this narration, awaiting is considered a type of action, not passivity and inactivity. Therefore, in answer to the question of what the duty of Muslims is in the era of occultation, it must be said: They must, through self-reform, reforming others, and building an exemplary society – i.e., by acting upon religious teachings and practical and verbal propagation – prepare the ground for the reappearance of the Master of the Age. Because the divine tradition is not that the fate of a nation is changed

through miracle and suddenly; rather, until their thought, psyche, and innate disposition (*fitrah*) are prepared, their fate will not change. The Quran states: "Indeed, Allah will not change the condition of a people until they change what is in themselves." (Quran 13:11) For self-reform, one must undoubtedly be pious and have good morals. Imam al-Sadiq said in this regard: "Whoever is happy to be among the companions of Imam al-Qa'im should be in a state of awaiting, and while awaiting, he should adopt piety and good morals."

****The Image of Human Society in the Era of Reappearance****

In the era of reappearance, oppression and corruption will vanish, and justice and equity will take their place in all pillars and dimensions of society. Some examples include:

1. The perfection and flourishing of rationality.
2. The expansion and perfection of knowledge, understanding, and wisdom.
3. The realization of unity and sincerity.
4. The development of religiosity and spirituality.
5. The perfection of morals.
6. The elimination of discrimination and the expansion of public welfare.
7. The realization of freedom.
8. The expansion of global peace.
9. The realization of comprehensive global justice.
10. Abundance of blessings and fertility and productivity of resources.
11. The expansion of security.
12. The elevation of living standards and the eradication of poverty.
13. The development of prosperity.
14. The advancement of industry and technology.
15. The preservation and health of the environment.
16. The realization of people's satisfaction.
17. The decline of false governments.

Part Five: Religious Authority (Marja'iyyah) and Guardianship (Wilayah) in the Era of Occultation

A) The Necessity of Establishing Governance in the Era of Occultation

****Introduction****

Social life is a prerequisite for the growth and perfection of human intellectual life, and the growth and perfection of human intellect depends on their social life. Humans are honored for possessing intellect because through its use, they can achieve extensive theoretical and practical knowledge. Now, imagine how a person could activate all the potential of their intellect without social life? If humans were forced to invent all human knowledge alone, how far could they progress? If we had no share in the knowledge of our time and did not inherit the wisdom accumulated from our ancestors, the knowledge we could acquire alone would be very little. Therefore, every person must be educated in society, learn the sciences of the past, then teach what they have learned to others, and, if possible, develop it further. Thus, a rational human is a social being.

The existence of governance in human social life is also counted as a natural, innate, and rational need and necessity. Its importance is such that no advanced and organized society can be found without governance. Governance is one of the pillars of a society; even primitive tribes were led by the tribal elder, and they also had a form of governance.

Naturally, the religion of Islam, as the final religion with instructions and programs for all essential human needs, also has a program for establishing governance. Islam has reasons for the necessity of establishing governance, which we briefly address:

1. ****The Model of the Prophet:**** The Prophet of Islam, the model for all Muslims, immediately established an Islamic governance upon entering Medina. He founded an army to protect the Islamic country, issued orders for war and peace, made treaties with certain groups, organized social and economic programs, implemented Islamic judicial laws, and appointed governors for other regions.

2. ****Governance in Islamic Teachings:**** Establishing governance is embedded in Islamic instructions and teachings. Some of these teachings include:

- * ****Unity:**** The unity of Muslims is not possible without governance. Islam is the religion of unity. God asks Muslims to follow the Quran, hold fast to the divine rope, and not become divided. For all people to follow the Quran, a governance must undoubtedly be established where the rulings of the Quran flow through all its systems, because the Quran is not limited to individual aspects and has a program for all dimensions of social life. Without governance as a

unifying factor, each group goes its own way, and Muslims become scattered, which is forbidden by the Quran.

* **Implementing Islamic Laws:** The laws of Islam are established for social, political, economic, cultural, judicial systems, etc. Undoubtedly, acting upon these laws is not possible without establishing governance. For example, Islam asks Muslims to prioritize justice in various dimensions in society, fight oppression, implement Islamic judicial rulings, and, to the extent possible, prepare armed forces.

It is evident that the necessity of implementing Islamic rulings and laws is not limited to the time of the Prophet and the infallible Imams; this necessity is eternal. Therefore, the wisdom behind establishing Islamic governance is also applicable during the occultation of the Master of the Age. Thus, governance must be established. Undoubtedly, the non-implementation of Islamic rulings is incompatible with the finality of the Islamic religion.

B) The Guardian-Jurist (Wali al-Faqih)

The Meaning of "Wilayat al-Faqih"

"Wilayat al-Faqih" is a compound of two words: "Wilayah" and "Faqih." To clarify, these two words must be explained:

* **Wilayah:** In Arabic, it is a word derived from "Wali," meaning the coming of one thing immediately after another without any interval. The implication of such a sequence is the closeness of the two to each other. Hence, this word, in various forms, is used to mean friendship, support and assistance, following, guardianship, authority over affairs, and leadership. The common aspect among all these meanings is spiritual proximity and connection. In terminology, and in the discussion of "Wilayat al-Faqih," it means guardianship and sovereignty. This word also appears in the Quran and narrations with the meaning of guardianship.

* **Faqih:** Lexically, it means a scholar and specialist in Islamic jurisprudence (*fiqh*) – in other words, someone knowledgeable about the permissible (*halal*) and forbidden (*haram*) rulings of Islam. In the discussion of "Wilayat al-Faqih," *Faqih* means a qualified jurist (*mujtahid*) who is knowledgeable about Islamic laws, just, pious, competent, a manager, and capable of leading the Islamic community.

Therefore, "Wilayat al-Faqih" means the sovereignty and leadership of a qualified jurist who, in the era of occultation, continues the path of the infallible Imams in implementing Islamic laws.

Historical Background of "Wilayat al-Faqih"

"Wilayat al-Faqih" in the era of occultation is not a newly emerged issue recently raised by jurists. Rather, on one hand, it has roots in the narrations of the Prophet and the infallible Imams, where jurists and *mujtahids* are referred to as the general deputies of the infallible Imam. On the other hand, after the occultation of the Master of the Age, great jurists and

mujtahids such as Shaykh al-Tusi, Ibn Idris, Allamah al-Hilli, al-Muhaqqiq al-Karki, Mulla Ahmad Naraqi, Shaykh Murtada al-Ansari, and Sahib al-Jawahar have discussed it.

In our time, Imam Khomeini practically implemented the theory of **"Wilayat al-Faqih"** and established a governance based on it. He stated: "The issue of ***Wilayat al-Faqih*** is not something new that we have brought; rather, this issue has been discussed from the beginning... In any case, this issue is not new, and we only examined the subject more and mentioned the branches of governance and made it available to gentlemen to clarify the issue... otherwise, the content is the same as many jurists have understood."

Regarding the characteristics and authority of the Guardian-Jurist, Imam Khomeini believed that the Guardian-Jurist is someone who is just and knowledgeable about Islamic laws and has the same authority that the Prophet and infallible Imams had in administering governance. When a jurist establishes a governance and wants to implement Islamic penal codes, or collect ***khums*** and ***zakat***, its manner and quantity are no different from what the infallibles did. Of course, one should not think that the status of jurists and the Prophet and Imams is the same; rather, governance is a common duty upon their shoulders. Also, **"Wilayat al-Faqih"** does not fall from the jurist's responsibility if it is not possible; whatever he can do, he must fulfill this responsibility. Of course, the governance of the jurist is within the limits of Islamic law and should not violate it, because Islamic governance is the governance of divine law.

****Objectives and Duties of the Guardian-Jurist's Governance****

In Islam, the goal of governance is to act upon divine commands, which are established for the material and spiritual happiness of humans. Islamic rulers see governance not as a means to enjoy material blessings but as a tool to establish truth and nullify falsehood. Undoubtedly, governance is a serious duty and trust that God has placed upon them. Therefore, governance in itself has no value for them.

Some objectives of the Guardian-Jurist's governance, which continues the mission of the Prophet and the infallible Imams, are the same as theirs:

1. By acting upon Islamic teachings and building an exemplary society, prepare the ground for establishing the global governance of the Master of the Age, because Islam is a global religion.
2. Establish justice in all pillars of governance and society, because Islam values justice so highly that it considers the Prophet's mission to be its execution.
3. Realize brotherhood and equality in society, because in our teachings, a believer is the brother of a believer, and a Muslim should consider the pain and joy of others as their own. Also, the Guardian-Jurist must enforce equality before the law.
4. Strive for the spiritual and material progress and comprehensive development of society in all scientific, cultural, economic, industrial, and agricultural dimensions, to the extent possible.
5. Ensure public security and the safety of life, property, and honor for all members of society.
6. Take care of public health and strive to improve the health and treatment levels of society.
7. Pay special attention to education and nurturing individuals for the development of a righteous and capable generation.

C) The Basis for the Legitimacy of the Guardianship of the Jurist

****The Source of Legitimacy****

One of the important issues regarding "**Wilayat al-Faqih**" is the basis for its legitimacy. Legitimacy means being rightful and valid, or having an acceptable and valid reason for something. Any authority, including "**Wilayat al-Faqih**," needs an acceptable reason to prove its sovereignty, which is called legitimacy.

In other words, when we ask what the legitimacy of a governance is, we mean: what acceptable criterion and reason do the individual(s) who have taken on administering a society and have authority over people's lives and property have for this position?

From the Islamic perspective, the right of sovereignty originally belongs to God, and no individual or group has such a right unless God has delegated it to someone for a reason. Based on definitive proofs, God has delegated this right to the Prophet and the twelve infallible Imams (with specific names and characteristics) and, in the era of occultation, by stating its characteristics, to the Guardian-Jurist.

But if asked: For what reason does the jurist have the right to govern in the era of occultation? The answer is that based on reason and authentic narrations, in the time of occultation, the deserving person for governance is the qualified **mujtahid** who is knowledgeable about Islamic laws, competent, and possesses moral virtues.

But what is the people's role in this governance? Undoubtedly, people must give practical existence to this governance and establish it, because without public acceptance, guardianship does not attain external reality.

Therefore, the people's role in this type of governance is only in its establishment and then its continuation, not in its fundamental proof (**thubut**). In reality, the realization of such governance is based on two foundations: one religious and doctrinal, and the other public opinion and popular acceptance.

Now, to the initial question of what acceptable attention or reason the sovereignty of the Guardian-Jurist has, it should be answered that such governance is, firstly, pleasing to God because it is rational and rooted in authentic verses and narrations, and secondly, the people are content with it because if they were not content, they would not realize it. Undoubtedly, these two reasons are acceptable for the realization of such governance, but each from a different angle: one from the angle of proof (**thubut**) and the other from the angle of realization and establishment.

****The Role and Place of the People in the System of "Wilayat al-Faqih"****

From the Islamic perspective, God created humans free. Therefore, they can, in light of their reasoning and free will, accept religious governance and **"Wilayat al-Faqih"** or reject it, just as the acceptance of religion itself is based on free will and awareness.

Furthermore, one of the established principles of Islamic jurisprudence is that every individual has authority over their own property, and no one can take this authority from them. The owner has the discretion to use their property as they wish while alive. Therefore, when we accept that every individual has authority over their own property and that disposal of others' property without their permission is not permissible, based on priority, it must be accepted that everyone also has authority over their own life, because authority over life takes precedence over authority over property.

On the other hand, governance of any kind necessitates a type of authority over people's lives and property, such as collecting taxes, participating in war, or implementing penal codes. How can these two points be reconciled? On one hand, people have authority over their own lives and property, and on the other hand, they need governance, and governance limits or takes away people's authority over their lives and property.

In response, we say that those who can have authority over people's lives and property must do so with their permission. Therefore, people have the right to accept a governance; meaning, with their own free will, they grant permission to another to dispose of their property and lives, or they can reject it.

Now the question is: Is any type of ruler and governance that people accept also valid according to religious law (**"shar"**)? The people's selection of governance can be imagined in two forms:

1. People have chosen governance in accordance with the criteria and characteristics mentioned in the Quran and the narrations of the Prophet and the infallible Imams. Therefore, this type of governance also enjoys religious and doctrinal validity. In other words, this type of governance is pleasing to God.
2. The selection of governance is not in accordance with the criteria mentioned in the Quran and narrations. In this case, such governance only has popular validity and does not conform to Islamic criteria. These people, who are among the wrongdoers, immoral, and disbelievers, have acted contrary to this Quranic teaching: "Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due..."

****Appointment or Election?****

Now, this fundamental question must be answered: Is the governance of the Guardian-Jurist by appointment (**"intisab"**) or election (**"intikhab"**)? In other words, is the Guardian-Jurist appointed to this position by God and the infallibles, or have the people chosen him?

The answer is that in appointive governance, appointment (**"nass"**) is used in two meanings: specific appointment (**"nass khass"**) and general appointment (**"nass 'amm"**).

* ****Specific appointment**** is when God appoints a specific individual with a specified name and characteristics to lead the Islamic community, as was the case with the Prophet and the infallible Imams.

* ****General appointment**** is when God and the infallibles have not specified a particular individual with a name and characteristics to lead the Islamic community. Rather, they have stated qualities and characteristics; whoever possesses them is qualified for leadership. Thus, in the era of occultation, the Guardian-Jurist acquires the right to govern through general appointment because the characteristics mentioned in verses and narrations for leadership are found in him. Therefore, his governance is accepted and pleasing to God and the infallibles. The people also have the duty to discover and identify this right of governance, which truly exists externally, and accept such governance.

Therefore, the governance of the Guardian-Jurist is, on one hand, appointive; meaning the qualities that the Quran and the infallibles have enumerated for leading the Islamic community exist in the Guardian-Jurist, and God's pleasure lies in such governance. Hence, such a leader is generally appointed by God.

But on the other hand, the governance of the Guardian-Jurist is elective; meaning the people must accept such governance through their own choice and vote for it to be realized and established. The Guardian-Jurist does not resort to force in the fundamental establishment of governance, just as the method of the Prophet and the infallible Imams was.

Consequently, the governance of the Guardian-Jurist is both appointive (in its fundamental proof) and elective (in its realization and establishment).

****Guardianship or Agency?****

One of the important questions regarding the governance of the Guardian-Jurist is whether this governance is based on guardianship (*wilayah*) or agency (*wikalah*).

* ****Agency-based governance**** is when the ruler receives their position and capacity from the people. Naturally, in this governance, the ruler (or agent) is their deputy and successor in securing their desires, even if contrary to religious law. In other words, the criterion for the ruler's decision is the people's (or clients') judgment. In this type of governance, the ruler has no legitimacy for governance before being chosen by the people. Therefore, people can choose anyone as their agent. In reality, this type of governance is based on popular opinion and decision.

* ****Guardianship-based governance**** is when the Islamic ruler, at least in terms of fundamental proof, receives their position and capacity from God and the infallibles. In this governance, the criterion for the ruler's decision-making is religious laws and the ruler's own judgment, which is also based on religious criteria. Furthermore, people cannot choose just anyone as ruler; rather, the Guardian-Jurist possesses conditions mentioned in the verses and narrations of the infallibles. Therefore, the leadership of the Islamic community is a divine covenant that does not reach everyone.

In this type of governance, the Guardian-Jurist, through general appointment, has the right from God to govern, but the people must accept such governance. In other words, this type of governance, unlike agency-based governance, rests on two foundations: the view of religion and doctrine, and popular acceptance.

****Critique and Analysis****

Agency-based governance is based on a human-centered viewpoint, meaning that governance and authority are the right of the people, and naturally, all its legitimacy returns to the people. This type of governance contradicts religious teachings because the right of governance and obedience belongs solely to God and those who have permission for governance from God. Also, considering the rational and narrative proofs for "**Wilayat al-Faqih**," such guardianship is fundamentally a divine position given by God and the infallible leaders of Islam to the Guardian-Jurist. On the other hand, the establishment of such governance is based on popular acceptance. Therefore, such governance cannot derive all its legitimacy from the people, whereas in agency-based governance, the ruler, who is the people's agent, derives all their legitimacy from the people. Thus, based on religious teachings, we cannot consider "**Wilayat al-Faqih**" as a form of agency.